# THE HEIRESS' AWAKENING

Written by
GoodShort

**EP. 1** *

1 EXT. CEMETERY - DUSK 1

CLAIRE COSTELLO stands before her mother's gravestone with a sorrowful expression, lost in memory.

BEGIN FLASHBACK: *

2 INT. HOSPITAL - ICU - DAY 2 *

CLAIRE'S MOTHER lies in bed, looking weak. Claire stands by the bedside with tears in her eyes, holding her mother's hand.

CLAIRE'S MOTHER
(gentle but worried)
Claire, as the Costello family's heir, you're gifted and have achieved remarkable success in the business world. But I don't want you to repeat the tragedies of your father and brother. Promise me you'll hide your identity and real name. Marry a good man, and live an ordinary life...

END FLASHBACK.

3 EXT. CEMETERY - DUSK 3 *

Claire places a bouquet of white roses on the gravestone and speaks softly.

CLAIRE
(slightly choked up)
Mom, I promise you, I'll hide who I am and live an ordinary life.

Claire stands. Behind her are luxury cars and uniformed bodyguards (two rows, six on each side). Butler GARY BECK stands at the front, respectfully awaiting her instructions.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
(firmly)
From today on, none of you need to follow me anymore. Gary, you'll manage the Costello family estate.

GARY
(nodding slightly)
As you wish, Miss.

Claire looks back at the gravestone one last time, then turns to leave.

4 INT. MARRIAGE REGISTRY OFFICE - DAY 4

Claire wears a simple wedding dress, standing beside KYLE RAMON. He holds Claire's hand, his eyes full of love.

CLOSE UP: Two marriage certificates in Claire's other hand.

KYLE
I, Kyle Ramon, swear to love only Claire Garcia for the rest of my life this life. I promise you, once my work in Europe is finished, I'll return to your side and we'll have a grand wedding ceremony.

CLAIRE
(tenderly)
Don't worry, I'll take good care of your mother and our home. I'll wait for you.

TRANSITIONAL SHOT: Camera pans to roses on the registry desk, then back.

5 INT. MARRIAGE REGISTRY OFFICE - DAY - ONE YEAR LATER 5 *

SUPERIMPOSED TEXT: ONE YEAR LATER *

We're still in the marriage registry office, but now the two are separated by a desk. Claire stands while Kyle, dressed in a suit, sits across from her. He looks arrogant and cold.

KYLE
Claire. I've fallen in love with my business partner, Sarah White, and we're getting married soon. Let's get divorced. This is the divorce agreement.

Kyle slides a document across the desk to Claire. CLOSE UP: The word "Divorce" is printed on the paper.

CLAIRE
(calm and composed)
Remember when you promised to love me and only me for the rest of your life?

KYLE
Forget that. I didn't know what I wanted back then. Then I met Sarah —she's talented and has achieved remarkable success in the business world. Only then did I realize how attractive an independent woman could be!

CLAIRE
Sarah White? I want to meet her.

**EP. 2**

6 INT. KYLE'S VILLA - LIVING ROOM - DAY 6

At the villa entrance, a pair of high heels steps gracefully out of a luxury car, exuding elegance.

The high heels walk directly into the villa.

CLOSE UP, FOLLOWING SHOT: As we hear the elegant sound of heels on the floor, SARAH WHITE (sunglasses and perfectly styled curls) makes a striking entrance.

Claire, Kyle, and PETUNIA RAMON (50's, Kyle's mother) are sitting in the living room. They look up as Sarah approaches.

EMILY LEE, the maid currently cleaning the counter in the open kitchen, also sneaks a glance.

Petunia rushes forward with an ingratiating smile, beaming.

PETUNIA
Sarah! Kyle's been telling me all about how wonderful you are. You're even more beautiful than you are in the photos!

SARAH
Oh, Kyle. That sounds just like him. He's always praising me to everyone.

CLAIRE
(slightly shocked, to Petunia)
You knew about this already?

PETUNIA
Of course! Sarah's from a prestigious family, and she's also an internationally renowned expert on AI and cybersecurity.
(to Sarah)
No wonder Kyle is so smitten with you. You must be tired after all that travel.

Sarah stands next to Kyle, exuding pride. *

SARAH
Kyle and I have been flying around the world for various projects in the past few years, so I'm used to it. Unlike some people who rarely leave the house. Claire, I heard you wanted to see me—do you have something to say?

Claire's expression returns to calm.

CLAIRE
I hear you're a pioneer for women's rights at the American Professional Women's Association. It seems like you're considered to be a role model for independent women. Does it set a good example for other women to interfere in someone else's marriage and trample on another women?

SARAH
(angered, sharp tone)
Your jealousy is showing! I hate women like you: you don't have a career and your life revolves around keeping house! Kyle and I are in love. You're the one who couldn't keep your husband, and you're attacking me? *

Sarah sits on the sofa and pushes the document on the table toward Claire again.

SARAH (CONT'D)
Just sign already. Trying to hold on only makes you more pathetic.

PETUNIA
You've always been sensible, Claire. Just sign the divorce papers and let's part ways cleanly. Don't stand in the way of Kyle's happiness.

Claire picks up the divorce agreement and flips through it. CLOSE UP: one page clearly states "Wife voluntarily relinquishes all marital property."

CLAIRE
(cold smile)
You're so eager to leave me with nothing.

SARAH
For all these years, I was the one supporting Kyle's career. Every penny that you spent was earned by the two of us. How dare you try to take our property? *

Claire's gaze pierces Kyle like a sword.

CLAIRE
Never mind that I never spent any of your money—I subsidized your whole family's daily expenses. Kyle, have you forgotten where your startup capital came from? And now you have an affair and want to leave me with nothing? I've never seen anything so shameless!

Kyle's expression instantly darkens, and Sarah's smile disappears.

**EP. 3**

7 INT. KYLE'S VILLA - LIVING ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 7 *

KYLE
(evasively)
You ignorant woman! The little money you could chip in meant nothing to me. A genius like me could have easily found other investors without your help.
(MORE)

KYLE (CONT'D)
All you care about is the money, right? If you sign, I'll be merciful and give you a million.

Sarah grabs Kyle's hand. *

SARAH
(maliciously)
Don't give her anything! Let's see what she can do about it. Hmph. If you wants to sue, I have the best legal team in California. So go ahead—try to bargain with us, make a scene. Let's see if you have what it takes.

CLAIRE
(coldly)
And what do you think about this, Mrs. Ramon?

PETUNIA
(arrogantly)
Seeing as you took care of me, Claire, I'll go easy on you andlet you stay as a maid. After all, what other job could a worthless housewife like you find?

Claire looks at Sarah.

CLAIRE
(with a cold smile)
What do you think of that, Ms. Pioneer-for-Women's-Rights?

SARAH
Sure. We'll keep you on...as a maid. But you'd better know your place. Don't try to seduce the man of the house.

CLAIRE
Well, when it comes to seduction, who could compete with certain women who speak of womens' rights then chase after married men?

SARAH
Don't push your luck, you bitch! Actually, I don't need a maid like you! You should fall from grace and end up on the streets!

Claire laughs, with a cold edge to it.

CLAIRE
Life is already hard enough for women. We have to deal with the pain of menstruation and childbirth, the toil of housework, the burden of misogyny—none of these are easy. And you two are women yourselves—why would you bully another woman like this?

SARAH
Bully? We're going easy on you! All you did was do some housework. What do you have to be proud of?

PETUNIA
(snorts contemptuously)
Exactly, you ungrateful little thing! A woman like you with no career and no background—without my son, you're nothing!

CLAIRE
You really think my worth needs to be defined by a worthless husband? Without me, Kyle wouldn't have succeeded at all. I should ask you: what right do you have to enjoy the fruits of that success?

SARAH
Ridiculous! You're just a housewife who does the chores. You really think you were behind to Kyle's success?

The onlooking maid, Emily, throws down the cloth she's holding and runs over.

EMILY
You're bullying her too much! Do you even know how dedicated and hardworking Miss Garcia was? She took care of the old mistress when she was sick and kept this household together!

Sarah raises her hand and slaps Emily.

SARAH
Shut up! What right do you have to interfere in your employers' business!?

Claire immediately slaps Sarah back.

CLAIRE
How dare you hit my employee!

**EP. 4**

8 INT. KYLE'S VILLA - LIVING ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 8 *

Sarah holds her cheek, looking at Claire in shock.

KYLE
(angry)
Claire! You're going too far!

SARAH
Ignorant idiot! How dare you compare your household chores to my career achievements? I helped Kyle * secure the Costello family's multi-billion dollar deal. Our company's stock price soared and its valuation increased tenfold. He's about to become the wealthiest man in California! Do you think you deserve him?

CLAIRE
America is a land of freedom equality. Why can't a housewife be compared to a career woman? Besides, how do you know I'm not the type of career woman you speak of?

KYLE
(sneering)
What th hell are you talking about? I know exactly what kind of person you are. A nobody like you can't hold a candle to Sarah!

SARAH
(triumphantly)
Face the facts, Claire. You don't deserve to stand next to us.

CLAIRE
You're the ones who don't deserve it. Fine, I agree to the divorce.

Claire decisively takes the pen, quickly signs the divorce agreement, pushes it toward Kyle, and stands up.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
(calmly)
From this day forward, we have nothing to do with each other.

**EP. 5**

9 INT. KYLE'S VILLA - LIVING ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 9 *

Petunia, Kyle, and Sarah all look smug. Claire stops suddenly as she's leaving.

CLAIRE
Oh, by the way, starting tomorrow, Dr. Brown won't be coming by to treat Petunia anymore. You'll need to find someone else.

Kyle freezes at these words, then suddenly stands up, losing control of his emotions.

KYLE
(angrily)
How can you be so heartless, Claire? You're abandoning my mother even though she's sick?

PETUNIA
You know Dr. Brown is the only one who can treat my condition! Are you trying to kill me, you bitch!?

CLAIRE
Dr. Brown only came as a personal favor to me. I took care of you because I considered you to be my family. But clearly, you never saw me as your own. When it comes to being heartless, I'm no match for you.

She leaves without looking back. The door slams shut, leaving only a fuming Kyle and Sarah, and a shocked Petunia in the villa.

10 EXT. KYLE'S VILLA - DAY 10

Claire takes out her phone and calls her butler, Gary.

CLAIRE
Gary, immediately cancel the multi-billion dollar contract that's about to be signed with Ramon Tech.

GARY
Yes, I'll take care of it right away. But you specifically instructed that contract be given to your husband's company...

CLAIRE
He's not my husband anymore.

Flames of revenge flicker in Claire's eyes.

CLAIRE (V.O.)
From this moment on, I will take back everything that I gave you.

**EP. 6**

11 INT. KYLE'S VILLA - LIVING ROOM - DAY 11 *

SARAH
What!? The multi-billion Costello deal was going perfectly. Why did it suddenly get cancelled? What's going on?

KYLE
I don't know either! I've already paid so many costs upfront, and now it's all turning into debt! Sarah, our wedding is going to cost a lot. Do you think we could delay it...

SARAH
(agitated)
No way, I already sent the invitations out!

KYLE
Then could we maybe lower the wedding budget?

SARAH
(angry)
The current arrangements are barely suitable as it is. Cutting costs further would be humiliating!

PETUNIA
My son's company is just having some temporary issues. Aren't you wealthy, Sarah? Since we'll be family soon, why don't you cover some of the costs for now?

SARAH
You want me to pay for the wedding? Marrying into your family was already beneath me, and now I have to worry about things like this?

KYLE
(breaking down)
Stop arguing! Invitations have already been sent the four major families. If we can get the Costello family leader's approval at the wedding, then there's still hope that the deal can go through!

SARAH
Hmph, it'd better!

12 INT. COSTELLO FAMILY MANSION - NIGHT 12

Claire stands by the window holding a glass of red wine, gazing into the night. Gary stands respectfully nearby.

CLAIRE
How are things?

GARY
As you instructed, I've arranged for Emily, the dismissed maid, to receive a new position: logistics manager at the Costello five-star hotel.

CLAIRE
Emily helped me a lot when she was working at Kyle's. She stood up for me and lost her job. She deserves a good position.

GARY
Also, Ramon Tech’s major investor Curtis Armstrong sends his regards. He’s hoping to meet with you.

Claire looks at a nearby shelf.

CLOSE UP: Photograph of Claire and Curtis toasting at a table, laughing happily.

CLAIRE
Don't tell Curtis about my divorce yet. Just say that everything's fine. As for a meeting, there’ll be more opportunities later. Gary, I've decided to return to the Costello family and manage the business again.

GARY
(hesitating)
Miss, according to the late Madam Costello’s will, you can only inherit the estate and manage the business after you’ve married. But now that you're divorced...

CLAIRE
(surprised, then thoughtful)
What? So I must remarry to regain the rights to my inheritance. Find me a partner for a contract marriage immediately!

**EP. 7**

13 EXT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - ROOFTOP - NIGHT 13

In the cold blue light, DANIEL GRIFFITH loosens his tie as he walks.

SUPER: Daniel Griffith - Head of the Griffith Family

EMPLOYEE S stands at the roof's edge with nowhere to run. He throws a punch at Daniel, who easily dodges. He ties his removed necktie around Employee S's neck, then swiftly lifts and dangles him upside down over the building's edge.

Employee S screams in terror as his life hangs by a thread.

DANIEL
(calmly)
Where are the original backend data files? Talk.

No response. Daniel loosens the tie slightly. Employee S realizes that he’s about to fall.

EMPLOYEE S
I'll talk, I'll talk!

Daniel pulls Employee S back up. Employee S lies on the ground panting, trembling as he hands over a small chip.

Daniel pockets the chip and turns to leave. His assistant, JACK WILSON, who was waiting at the corner, follows.

Daniel fixes his clothes as he walks briskly.

DANIEL
What's so urgent?

JACK
The latest news, sir. It’s about Claire Costello.

Daniel freezes at this name.

BEGIN FLASHBACK: *

14 EXT. SCHOOL - DAY 14

In a luxury car, Jack sits in the driver's seat. Daniel is in the back wearing an expensive suit, with a large beautiful bouquet beside him.

JACK
Boss, is this the Miss Costello you've been thinking about for ten years?

Claire walks out. Daniel watches her silently, his eyes full of love.

As Daniel reaches to open the car door, through the window he sees Kyle, wearing a simple plaid shirt, running up to Claire with a single flower.

KYLE
Claire, will you be my girlfriend?

Claire smiles and nods, Kyle hugs her happily.

Daniel witnesses all this through the car window. Fighting heartbreak, he puts away the bouquet and closes the window.

END FLASHBACK.

15 EXT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - ROOFTOP - NIGHT 15

Daniel and his assistant have reached the elevator.

JACK
Kyle brought another woman home and forced Miss Claire to agree to a divorce. She’s now looking for a contract marriage partner...

DANIEL
Get the car ready. I want to see her in ten minutes.

The elevator opens and Daniel strides in.

JACK
(flustered)
Ten minutes? But it's not even dawn yet, Boss!

**EP. 8**

16 EXT. PATHWAY - DAY 16

MR. SMITH walks alone in a suit, talking on the phone. Butler Gary's voice comes through.

GARY (V.O.)
Miss Costello will be waiting for you at the marriage registry office at 10 AM, Mr. Smith.

MR. SMITH
Good, I'm on my way.

Mr. Smith barely hangs up when a car stops beside him, and two large men quickly force him into it.

Daniel steps gracefully out of the car, wearing sunglasses and a suit with dress shoes, looking very handsome. Jack leans out from the driver's seat.

JACK
Leave the rest to me. Good luck, Boss!

17 INT. MARRIAGE REGISTRY OFFICE - DAY 17

Claire sits at the table alone. Daniel walks straight over and sits across from her.

DANIEL
Hello, Miss Costello. I'm your contract marriage partner.

Claire glances at Mr. Smith's photo on her phone screen, and responds coldly.

CLAIRE
You're not Mr. Smith.

DANIEL
But I'm more suitable.

Daniel slides a pad in front of Claire, showing data for tampered logs.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
The Costello family car accident wasn't an accident. This is the original data from the vehicle.

CLAIRE
What are you saying?

DANIEL
Though the backend commands were erased, the vehicle system shows that someone tampered with the instructions, causing a brake failure.

CLAIRE
(puzzled)
How do you know this?

DANIEL
You don't need to understand it all right now. If you want the truth, let's make a deal: marry me, and I'll help you find the truth.

*** PAYWALL ***

**EP. 9**

18 INT. MARRIAGE REGISTRY OFFICE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 18 *

CLAIRE
Seems you understand this marriage is just a business deal. Everyone is here is chasing after the reward—what about you?

DANIEL
You don't need to worry about what I want.

Claire moves closer to Daniel, speaking deliberately and with intimidation.

CLAIRE
I'm not an easy person to deal with, you know. If you're planning anything sneaky, you're dead.

DANIEL
(smiling)
Of course I know. You are Claire Costello, after all.

CUT TO

19 EXT. MARRIAGE REGISTRY OFFICE - DAY 19

Daniel and Claire exit through the main doors, each holding a marriage certificate.

CLAIRE
I'll divorce you in one year. Then I'll give you a villa downtown and fifty million dollars as compensation.

DANIEL
(smiling)
Hmm, those are very good terms. Well then, pleasure doing business with you.

CLAIRE
Yes. Pleasure doing business.

Claire puts the marriage certificate in her bag and calmly shakes Daniel's hand.

Gary approaches, holding a gold-embossed invitation.

GARY
Miss, Kyle and Sarah have sent wedding banquet invitations to all four major families in California.

CLAIRE
They really don't know their place.

DANIEL
(smiling)
I wonder how Kyle would react if he knew his ex-wife is actually the same Costello family leader that he's so desperate to impress.

Claire takes the invitation, giving a cold laugh.

CLAIRE
Tell him I'll attend. But first, I need to put on my "battle armor."

**EP. 10**

20 INT. LUXURY BOUTIQUE - DAY 20

Claire enters a dress boutique in the mall. SALESWOMAN A glances at her and smirks disdainfully.

SALESWOMAN A
Miss, the dresses here are quite expensive. I'm afraid they're not suitable for someone like you.

CLAIRE
Excuse me, were you speaking to me?

SALESWOMAN A
Who else? Is there another poor person in here?

CLAIRE
Judging people by appearances is very dangerous, Miss. I'm shocked that someone like you works here.

SALESWOMAN A
Rude little tramp...

Sarah's shrill voice cuts in.

SARAH (O.S.)
Well, well, well! Look who it is.

Claire and the saleswoman turn. Sarah walks over exuding confidence, holding Kyle's arm. Saleswoman A immediately rushes over warmly.

SALESWOMAN A
Miss White, you're finally here! We just got a new batch of dresses, and we wanted you to be the first to see them!

KYLE
(sneering)
Claire? Huh, since when can the poor just waltz into luxury stores?

SARAH
Hmph. She's just a housewife who got dumped. How could she possibly buy anything here? She's probably here to steal something.
(to Saleswoman A)
You better watch her carefully.

CLAIRE
How ironic - the pot calls the kettle black. You're a serial man-stealer, and you still have the nerve to accuse others of stealing?

**EP. 11**

21 INT. LUXURY BOUTIQUE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 21 *

KYLE
Enough, you jealous woman!, I know you're trying to get my attention and win me back, Claire. But listen carefully: I only have eyes for Sarah. If you keep pestering me, don't blame me if I get upset!

CLAIRE
You think too highly of yourself, Kyle. Between you and Sarah, one is an ungrateful cheater and the other is a shameless homewrecker. Every extra second I spend talking to you feels like a waste of my life.

SARAH
(laughing sarcastically)
Claire, this act is so pathetic.
(MORE)

SARAH (CONT'D)
Let me give you some advice: get out of here, before you make a bigger fool of yourself.

CLAIRE
You're not in a position to tell me that.

SARAH
Oh, you're quite bold. Well, I won't let you off easy. Today, I'll show you the difference between you, a poor low-life, and us, the upper class!
(To Saleswoman A)
Which one of these gowns are your most expensive ones?

Saleswoman A walks over to a display shelf.

SALES ASSOCIATE A
They're all here, Ms. White. You're so beautiful, you'll look stunning in any one of them!

CLAIRE
These dresses aren't even the top-tier dresses for this brand.

SARAH
You lowly bottom-feeder, have you ever worn a dress like this in your life? This is nothing like the cheap stuff you buy from the wholesale market. You probably can't even afford a single thread on the cheapest dress here, so quit being so picky.

SALES ASSOCIATE A
Exactly, Ms. White. Don't listen to her. She's never seen anything like this. It's just sour grapes.

Claire points to an ornate, elegant gown.

CLAIRE
This dress is the most expensive one in this store. It was custom-made for me by Miss Harper.

CLOSE-UP: The price tag clearly reads: $100,000.

22 INT. LUXURY BOUTIQUE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 22 *

SALES ASSOCIATE A
You must be crazy. How dare you pretend to know our head designer? Miss Harper, is the chief haute couture designer certified by the French Federation of Couture. She never accepts commissions and hasn't done any private work in a long time.

SARAH
Exactly! Even I haven't met Miss Harper yet. How can you, an impoverished former housewife, dare pretend to know her!

KYLE
Looks like your lies have been exposed. Aren't you embarrassed, Claire? Just get out of here, and spare yourself the further humiliation

CLAIRE
I have an appointment with Miss Harper to try on dresses here today. When she arrives, everything will be cleared up.

SARAH
Ha! What a convincing performance. You're just making this up to one-up me, aren't you? But this dress really is high-end.
(To Saleswoman A)
Wrap it up for me.

CLAIRE
(coldly)
You can't take this dress.

SARAH
Ridiculous! I'm one of the top five VIPs here in terms of annual spending. You—you low-life whose husband abandoned her, you pathetic housewife, how dare you try and compete with me?

CLAIRE
Take a closer look at the size of the dress. It was custom-made and tailored to fit me.

SARAH
There are plenty of people with the same size as you. I'll take this dress, and have the designers adjust it to my size.

Saleswoman A looks surprised and hesitant.

CLAIRE
(smiling slightly)
I told you, you can't take this dress.

KYLE
(scornfully)
Claire, stop it. If Sarah can't take it, does that mean you can?

DANIEL (O.S.)
Of course she can.

Daniel makes a dramatic entrance and stands beside Claire.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
I'll give you this dress.

**EP. 13**

23 INT. LUXURY BOUTIQUE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 23 *

Saleswoman A, Kyle, and Sarah look at the plainly dressed Daniel with disdain.

SARAH
(scoffing)
Oh, you found a new lover so quickly. By the looks of it...is he a gigolo?

KYLE
Claire, I know getting divorced was a huge blow to you. It's normal for you to miss a man as excellent as me. But I didn't expect you to hit rock bottom and hire a gigolo.

Sarah glances at their attire.

SARAH
I think they're a perfect match. They've both got the stench of poverty. I feel like I'm lowering myself just by talking to them.

KYLE
(to Daniel)
Hey, poor boy, do you recognize this brand? Do you know how much this dress costs? And you still dare to set foot into this shop?

DANIEL
I don't need to look at the price tag to buy something. I could buy the whole store if I wanted to, let alone one dress.

SARAH
(laughing)
One dress? This dress costs $100,000! That's more money than you'll ever earn in your lifetime, poor boy!

KYLE
Hmph, you have the delusions of a rich man and none of the wealth. I don't think this boytoy has any other skills besides bragging. He's just as fake as that bitch Claire.

SARAH
I can't wait to see these poor fools admit defeat and get kicked out of here.

DANIEL
You two should be the ones who get kicked out.

Daniel pulls out a black credit card and slams it on the counter. Saleswoman A is shocked.

SALESWOMAN A
This is... a Centurion black card?!

SARAH
(incredulously)
How could he own a card like that?

Claire grabs the card and hands it back to Daniel.

CLAIRE
No need for that, I've already paid. This dress is mine.

SALESWOMAN A
Hmph. You two sure are putting on a show! I bet this credit card is fake too. I've seen plenty of people like you: poor AND shameless. Security! Get these two out of here! Don't ruin the shopping experience for our valued customers!

Two burly security guards in uniform appear and approach Claire.

MISS HARPER (O.S.)
Stop! I think you're the one who should leave this boutique!

MISS HARPER walks in: she's a middle-aged woman dressed in a vintage and elegant style, with a lot of personality.

SALES ASSOCIATE A
(surprised)
Miss Harper?

**EP. 13**

24 INT. LUXURY BOUTIQUE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 24 *

MISS. HARPER
Who gave you permission to treat my valued customer like that? An employee like you is a disgrace to my reputation!

Saleswoman A looks shocked.

SALESWOMAN A
What? Valued customer?

Claire remains calm. Saleswoman A hurriedly bows and apologizes to Claire.

SALESWOMAN A (CONT'D)
I'm so sorry! Please forgive me!

SARAH
(disbelief)
Impossible!
(MORE)

SARAH (CONT'D)
A simple housewife like her, who doesn't even own a decent dress, and who was left with nothing after her divorce—how could she be the owner of this haute couture gown?

CLAIRE
Does a housewife deserve to be shabby for her entire life? Does she never deserve to wear something beautiful? Sarah, you truly give meaning to the phrase "looking down on others."

KYLE
You were left with nothing after I divorced you. Where did you get the money to buy this? You bitch, did you hide money from me?

CLAIRE
(scornfully)
Only you would think that someone would care so much about your measly fortune.

SARAH
Maybe she got this dress through some illicit means! A lower-class woman like her must have sold her body to some rich man just to satisfy her vanity.

MISS. HARPER
(angry)
All of you, shut up! Claire is my valued customer. This gown was designed specifically for her!

Miss Harper impatiently points at Kyle and Sarah. *

MISS. HARPER (CONT'D)
You two are not welcome here!
(To the security guards)
Get these two nasty little shits out of here!

SARAH
Why? I'm a VIP, you have no right to treat me like this!

MISS. HARPER
Your VIP card is canceled, starting today.
(MORE)

MISS. HARPER (CONT'D)
I will never let a dress designed by me be worn by an ill-mannered upstart like you!

Two burly security guards step forward and escort Saleswoman A, Kyle, and Sarah out.

SARAH
(gritting her teeth)
You'll pay for this, Claire!

**EP. 14**

25 EXT. DEPARTMENT STORE - DAY 25 *

Sarah, fuming, exits the department store and turns on Kyle.

SARAH
Claire actually had the head designer custom-make a dress for her! Didn't you say she was just an ordinary person?

KYLE
Now that I think about it, she mentioned having a relative who's a designer. That was probably Miss Harper.

SARAH
I hope so!

Kyle tries to calm her down.

KYLE
Don't let it get to you, darling. The heads of the Costello family and the Griffith family have both accepted our invitation!

SARAH
(anger turning to joy)
You mean they'll both be at our wedding?

KYLE
That's right. There's still a chance we can get back that canceled billion-dollar deal! Then that bitch Claire won't even be qualified to lick our boots.

26 INT. DEPARTMENT STORE - DAY 26

Claire and Daniel walk out of the store side by side.

CLAIRE
Why did you come?

Daniel hefts the bag in his hand, which contains the dress.

DANIEL
I came to pay for you. And to carry your bags.

CLAIRE
Speaking of which, who are you, really? How come you have an Centurion card?

DANIEL
I am...the head of the Griffith family.

**EP. 15**

27 INT. DEPARTMENT STORE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 27 *

Claire bursts out laughing. *

CLAIRE
If it were any other family, I might actually believe you.

DANIEL
Oh? Why don’t you believe me?

CLAIRE *
Everyone knows that the new head of the Griffith family is a reclusive weirdo. I heard he was raised by foster parents when he was a kid and was only formally recognized by the family when he was a teenager. Someone like that wouldn’t just randomly get married.

DANIEL
I suppose that's true. Well, your battle armor is ready. Are we ready to make our move?

CLAIRE
It's going to be a good show. Want to watch it together?

DANIEL
I'd be honored. By the way, there's been some progress in the investigation. Based on the current chain of information, Sarah may have been involved in that car accident.

Claire immediately recalls that day.

BEGIN FLASHBACK: *

28 EXT. DESERTED ROAD - DAY 28

After the car accident. Claire rushes to the scene and witnesses her father and brother being carried out, covered in white sheets.

TRANSITIONAL SHOT: to a TV screen showing the same scene, of the bodies being carried out. CLAIRE's mother drops to her knees, in front of the white sheet, crying hysterically, and then faints.

REPORTER (V.O.)
At the launch event for the Costello Group's new smart car, Chairman Ethan Costello and his heir Edward Costello died in a car accident. The chairman's wife fainted due to grief and was rushed to the hospital...

END FLASHBACK.

29 INT. DEPARTMENT STORE - DAY 29

CLAIRE
If Sarah really was involved, then I'll have to settle the score. For new and old grievances.

**EP. 16**

30 INT. BANQUET HALL - NIGHT 30

The banquet hall is adorned with twinkling lights. Tables are laden with exquisite food. Guests mingle in groups, clinking champagne glasses.

Sarah, arm in arm with Kyle, stands under a central light fixture. Both are dressed in wedding attire.

KYLE
(smugly)
Thank you for coming to this wedding! Sarah and I have invited some very important guests tonight. You won't be disappointed! *

GUEST A
Did you invite Curtis Armstrong, the famous investor? It would be such an honor to meet him!

KYLE
Mr. Armstrong will be here. And we'll also have the heads of the Griffith and Costello families.

GUEST A
That's incredible!

GUEST B
(flatteringly)
Congratulations! *

GUEST C
I'll need to rely on you two more in the future. Don't forget about your old friends on your way up!

SARAH
(giggling)
Of course. Everyone will have a chance to share in it.

KYLE
Haha, that's right! Everyone, eat and drink to your heart's content today. Let's celebrate our bright future together.

Kyle raises his glass, and the guests follow suit.

Just then, the banquet hall doors open, and a couple enters Claire and Daniel, side by side.

Kyle notices Claire's arrival and frowns.

KYLE (CONT'D)
(coldly)
Claire? What are you doing here? I didn't invite you.

31 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 31 *

PETUNIA
What a shameless little bitch. My son dumped her and she still has the nerve to show up. Like a piece of gum stuck to a shoe. How disgusting!

SARAH
So, you think bringing a gigolo to your ex-husband's wedding will help you save face? What kind of man could a divorced, poor woman like you find? You must have hired for cheap.

CLAIRE
(calmly)
Daniel is my husband. As for me, I came because I received your invitation.

SARAH
We know very well who was invited. Claire, I know you want to get back at us, but you shouldn't tell such a blatant lie.

KYLE
Are you trying to sneak in here to meet some of my connections and make a comeback? Why don’t you take a look in the mirror, you lower-class scum. Even if you’re shameless enough to come here, no one will pay any attention to you!

PETUNIA
(haughtily)
Exactly. My son invited all the big shots in California, including the heads of two of the four major families. How could we possibly invite someone as poor and troublesome as you?

DANIEL
If I remember correctly, one of the top four families is the Griffith family, right?

KYLE
Yes, the Griffith family is second only to the Costello family.

DANIEL
Coincidentally, the head of the Griffith family is me.

**EP. 18**

32 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 32 *

SARAH
(doubtfully)
You're the head of the Griffith family? Ha! You're taking advantage of the fact that the head of the Griffith family is very mysterious and never shows their face. Still. Bold move, pretending to be him.

KYLE
(arrogantly)
You’re hanging around a divorced woman, wearing a knock-off suit, and don’t even have one bodyguard. If you’re the head of the Griffith family, then I'm the head of the Costello family! *

PETUNIA *
Exactly. My son is a worldly young entrepreneur who's already made it into the top ten richest people in California. You won’t be able to fool him with these tricks!

SARAH
There are many wealthy and influential guests here today. Do you think you can just con everyone with a few words?

KYLE
Get out of here. When the real head of the Griffith family arrives, and you offend our distinguished guests, even your lives won't be enough to pay the price.

DANIEL
I'm quite offended right now.

SARAH
Wow, you're really getting into your act!

Claire leans in and whispers to Daniel, worried.

CLAIRE
Hey. Don't worry, I'm here. You don't have to act so tough, it'll just backfire.

DANIEL
Don't worry, nothing will happen to us. I promise.

Daniel looks at everyone with a cold, steady gaze.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
I'll say this one last time. If we don't deserve to be here, then no one here today deserves to be here.

KYLE
Why should we listen to the orders of a divorced housewife and a gigolo? You have no idea what you're talking about!

CLAIRE
(calm and forceful)
You're the ones who have no idea what they're talking about.



33 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 33 *

Claire walks up to Kyle and Sarah.

CLAIRE
Kyle, you and this so-called independent woman could only climb to where you are today because you were standing on my shoulders. You haven't even actually taken off yet, and you're already so arrogant.

SARAH
(laughing scornfully)
Please use your brain before you brag.
(MORE)

SARAH (CONT'D)
What contribution can a poor housewife like you make to a publicly listed company?

CLAIRE
The startup funds for Kyle's company primarily came from me. *

KYLE
Come on, Claire, do you know how much money it takes to invest in a company? Ramon Tech's major * shareholder is the famous investor Curtis Armstrong! A genius like me can easily find top-notch investors like him.

PETUNIA
My son is about to cooperate with * the Costello family and make a billion-dollar deal! Countless people are trying to cozy up to him, especially incompetent, vain women like you. Give up the act and leave while you still have some dignity.

CLAIRE
As far as I know, Kyle's billion-dollar order with the Costello family has been canceled.

The crowd enters an uproar. Kyle is panicked.

**EP. 20**

34 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 34 *

SARAH
You're lying! Kyle, I think she's here to ruin our wedding! She's even willing to spread lies to do it! You vicious, jealous bitch!

CLAIRE
(calmly)
Jealous? What do you have that I would be jealous of?

SARAH *
You're nothing but a parasite who leeches off men. But me?
(MORE)

SARAH (CONT'D)
I'm the driving force behind Kyle's success. We're a perfect match. Of course you're jealous of me. *

KYLE
That's right. My success is firstly because I'm a genius. And secondly because I had the help of an outstanding partner like Sarah. As for you—it's a disgrace to be associated with a worthless, jealous, manipulative woman like you. Every day I spent with you was like torture!

DANIEL
You two are overestimating yourselves and underestimating Claire.

PETUNIA
What is there to admire about this bitch? She's always clung to my son. Now that she can't have him, she tries to ruin him. How despicable!
(To Kyle)
Kyle, don't show her any mercy!

KYLE
Security, get these shameless people out of here!

Two guards immediately step forward to expel them. *

However, before the guards can touch Claire, Daniel steps in front of her and shields her with his body without hesitation.

Claire looks at Daniel profile, her heart inexplicably beating faster. Just then, a voice comes from off-screen.

CURTIS (O.S.)
Sorry I'm late, everyone!

**EP. 21**

35 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 35 *

CURTIS ARMSTRONG, a middle-aged man with a commanding presence, walks towards the center of the banquet hall.

KYLE
That's Curtis Armstrong, the major shareholder of our company! He's finally here!

SARAH
(excitedly)
The legendary shareholder? I can’t belive I finally get to meet him.

KYLE
He was the one who invested in me. With him backing me up, we'll definitely be able to turn things around.

Kyle quickly strides forward to greet the guest.

KYLE (CONT’D)
Mr. Armstrong, I'm so happy to see you on such an important day!

Curtis stands in front of Kyle and smiles playfully.

CURTIS
Congratulations, Kyle. You've certainly married a good woman! Without her silently supporting you, building bridges and paving the way for your career, you wouldn't be where you are today! She deserves a grand wedding!

KYLE
I know. She's helped me a lot over the years. I’m lucky to marry her.

A hint of triumph flashes in Sarah’s eyes.

CURTIS
Very well, very well. You two have stood by each other through thick and thin, supporting each other all the way. What a beautiful story!

Sarah steps forward, assuming a humble posture.

SARAH
(coyly)
Mr. Armstrong, I didn't know that you thought so highly of me. I'm not worthy of such praise.

Curtis looks at her and furrows his brow slightly.

CURTIS
(puzzled)
And...who are you?

The smile on Sarah’s face freezes.

**EP. 22**

36 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 36 *

SARAH
I'm Kyle's wife, Sarah.

Curtis is startled and looks surprised.

CURTIS
You're his wife? What happened to Claire?

KYLE
Claire and I are divorced.

CURTIS
(surprised)
Divorced? Isn't this a wedding for you and Claire?

SARAH
Claire, you've really outdone yourself. You must have hidden the divorce from everyone, trying to use Ramon Tech’s popularity to your advantage!

CLAIRE
Honestly, I forgot to announce the divorce.

CURTIS
Claire, what's going on?

CLAIRE
I was invited to attend my ex-husband's wedding.

SARAH
Mr. Armstrong, please don't listen to this woman. She's lying! She showed up uninvited, trying to...

CURTIS
(interrupting sternly)
I'm asking Claire, not you!
(MORE)

CURTIS (CONT'D)
(turning to Claire, gently)
How could this happen? I remember you two had a great relationship. Did Kyle mistreat you?

CLAIRE
Curtis, I misjudged people in the past. Please allow me to announce to everyone now that Kyle and I have agreed to a divorce and no longer have any association with each other. And now I have my new husband, Daniel.

**EP. 23**

37 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 37 *

PETUNIA
You see that, Mr. Armstrong? She got married right after her divorce. She must have been cheating on Kyle! Hmph, lazy AND promiscuous!

CLAIRE
Your son cheated on me while we were married and now he's blaming me? Well, don't blame me if I get ruthless.

Claire taps her phone a few times, and a photo suddenly appears on a large screen in the background.

The photo shows Kyle and Sarah, both disheveled, lying on a bed. Kyle is intimately embracing Sarah and kissing her cheek. *

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
See the time stamp in the bottom right corner? This is during my marriage to Kyle.

CURTIS
Kyle, you were cheating on her while you were married!?

KYLE
(incredulously)
How did you get that photo?

CLAIRE
I have my ways.
(holding up the divorce agreement)
Then, Kyle came to my house with Sarah and forced me to sign this divorce agreement, leaving me with nothing.

Curtis takes the divorce agreement and glances at it.

CURTIS
Alright, cheating on your wife is bad enough. Then you also forced her to sign a divorce agreement that would leave her with nothing? Kyle, I never thought you were such an ungrateful person!

**EP. 24**

38 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 38 *

KYLE
(urgently)
That's not true! She's taking things out of context! I said I'd give her compensation! Claire, you have to tell them. I offered compensation, but you refused!

CLAIRE
I gave you all my support, and you what did you repay me with? A waiver and a divorce agreement. Then you offered me some scraps to get me to sign it. You expect me to be grateful for that?

SARAH
Stop twisting the truth! Kyle and I worked together to create Ramon Tech. What did you contribute?

Curtis raises his voice angrily.

CURTIS
The only one twisting the truth is you! Claire is the founder of Ramon Tech. Without her help, the company would never have gotten off the ground. And you wouldn't be enjoying your success today!

SARAH
Mr. Armstrong, as far as I know, Claire hasn't been involved in Ramon Tech at all.

CURTIS
The first round of startup funding for Ramon Tech came from Claire. She’s an original investor in the company and also the reason I decided to invest further. Without Claire's introduction, I wouldn't have put in one penny!

GUEST A
Oh my god, so Kyle's company only started thanks to his ex-wife! That's so ironic!

GUEST B
I thought Sarah was the unsung hero, but she's actually a fraud who took all the credit.

DANIEL
Ms. White and Mr. Ramon are quite a pair...when it comes to stealing other people's achievements.

CURTIS
(decisively)
Starting today, I am officially withdrawing all my investments from Ramon Tech. A company like this is not worthy of my trust.

**EP. 25**

39 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 39 *

KYLE
(urgently)
No, Mr. Armstrong. Our personal issues have nothing to do with the company.

PETUNIA
(whispering to Kyle)
Kyle, what's going on? Claire is just a housewife. How can she be so important to Mr. Armstrong?

KYLE
I didn't expect this either...

PETUNIA
Mr. Armstrong, we've never denied Claire's contributions.
(to Claire)
After all, you were once my daughter-in-law. I even tried to persuade you, but you refused. *

CLAIRE
Stay? You meant you wanted me to stay on as a maid to serve your family?

Petunia is speechless.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
You also said that I'm nothing without Kyle, and that I should be grateful you'd keep me on as the maid. Isn't that right?

PETUNIA
Claire, I can understand your resentment, but anyone can see that an entrepeneur like my son, an entrepreneur is better suited for a successful, independent woman like Sarah. Must you ruin Kyle's future just to be happy? *

SARAH
You didn't chip in when I was working hard to supoprt Kyle. Now you want a piece of the pie, and when you don't get it, you get angry? How petty!

CLAIRE
You wanted me to announce the divorce, so I did. As for Kyle's company, since you all chose to leave nothing to me, it has nothing to do with me.

Claire glances at her watch, her expression cold.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
Oh, by the way, I purchased the villa you're living in before our marriage. I'm officially reclaiming my ownership.
(MORE)

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
Your wedding night will have to take place somewhere else.

Kyle and Sarah are stunned, as if struck by lightning.

**EP. 26**

40 INT. BANQUET HALL - DAY - CONTINUOUS 40 *

SARAH
You vicious little bitch! Why are you doing this to us?

CLAIRE
(calmly and sarcastically)
When you were hooking up with a married man and taking someone else's place, did you ever think about how vicious you were being? Now you play the victim.

Sarah glares at Kyle through gritted teeth.

SARAH
The house is hers, too? You're such a waste of space!

Claire turns and leaves.

KYLE
Claire, do you really hate me that much? Or did you never truly love me? How can you be so cold-blooded and heartless?

Claire continues walking out without looking back. Kyle tries to chase after Claire and grab her, but is stopped by Daniel.

DANIEL
You're the one who betrayed her. What right do you have to question Claire?

With that, Daniel turns and leaves.

41 INT. DANIEL'S OFFICE - DAY 41

Daniel sits at his desk, looking at his laptop. His assistant, Jack, rushes in.

JACK
Boss, it looks like Sarah White is holding a grudge. She’s been trying to find someone to "take care of" Ms. Costello. She might be in danger!

DANIEL
(serious)
Looks like someone needs to be assigned to protect her.

**EP. 27**

42 EXT. COSTELLO FAMILY MANSION - NIGHT 42

Claire steps out of a luxury car and sees Daniel standing at the door with a suitcase.

CLAIRE
(surprised)
Daniel? What are you doing here?

DANIEL
There's something I need your help with. To put it simply, I have nowhere to stay. Given that we were contractually married, could you take me in for now?

CLAIRE
(suspicious)
You have a Centurion black card, and you can't find a place to stay? What are you really up to, Daniel?

DANIEL
You trust your business partners unconditionally, don’t you?

CLAIRE
There are quite a few empty rooms in the villa. But let me make something clear. You're not allowed to enter my room without mypermission.

DANIEL
(smiling gently)
Thank you, Miss Costello, for taking me in.

43 INT. COSTELLO FAMILY MANSION - CLAIRE'S BEDROOM - NIGHT 43

Claire stands alone in front of the mirror, twisting her arm backward and trying to pull down the zipper on the back of her dress, but the zipper is stuck. She groans softly. *

CLAIRE
Why won't this come off...

She pulls hard,, several times without success.

Just then, the lights in the room suddenly go out.

44 INT. COSTELLO FAMILY MANSION - DANIEL'S BEDROOM - NIGHT 44

In another bedroom, Daniel is also plunged suddenly into darkness. He looks serious.

DANIEL (V.O.)
This is bad. Claire’s in danger!

He quickly gets out of bed and leaves the room.

**Episode 28**

45 INT. COSTELLO FAMILY MANSION - CLAIRE’S BEDROOM - NIGHT 45 *

Claire fumbles for the light switch. Nothing happens, startling her.

CLAIRE
(whispering)
Power outage?

The door creaks open with a soft noise. Footsteps echo in the quiet darkness.

CLAIRE (CONT’D)
(cautious)
Who’s there?

Daniel stops behind Claire, his voice low and measured.

DANIEL
Looks like you could use some help. *

CLAIRE
Daniel? You really are everywhere, aren’t you?

DANIEL (V.O.)
Thank god she’s okay.

DANIEL
If you want to talk semantics, I'm always where you need me.

Claire doesn't object. Daniel smiles faintly. His fingers trace the zipper on her dress, slowly pulling it downward. His fingertips graze her bare back, sending a faint shiver through her.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
Relax.

In the darkness, Claire's breathing steadies, though her heartbeat grows louder. The jammed zipper finally comes free.

CLAIRE
Thank you—

She turns to face him confidently, catching Daniel averting his gaze, seemingly embarrassed. Amused, Claire leans in slightly, trying to read his expression by the faint moonlight, a playful smile on her lips.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
Are you blushing? You don't seem like the kind of man who would be shy.

Daniel, cornered, meets her gaze directly, as if challenging her.

DANIEL
I'm curious— In your eyes, what kind of man am I? *

CLAIRE
Sharp-eyed. Once you've locked onto your prey, you never let go—like a panther.

Claire moves closer, the space between them charged with tension.

DANIEL
(low, dangerous)
You're not wrong, Claire.

Their eyes lock, Daniel's gaze intense. Their breaths mingle, the air thick with anticipation as something between them seems inevitable...

**Episode 29**

46 INT. COSTELLO FAMILY MANSION – CLAIRE'S BEDROOM – NIGHT – CONTINUOUS 46 *

At this exact moment, the voice of the butler, Gary, calls out from outside the room.

GARY (O.S.)
Miss Claire, there was a power outage. I checked the circuits, but it'll take some time to fix. Are you all right?

DANIEL
Claire's fine. I'm with her.

47 INT. COSTELLO FAMILY MANSION – HALLWAY OUTSIDE CLAIRE'S BEDROOM – NIGHT 47 *

The elderly butler is surprised. But remains composed.

GARY
Understood.

48 INT. COSTELLO FAMILY MANSION – CLAIRE'S BEDROOM – NIGHT 48 *

CLAIRE
Why did you suddenly come to my room? Did you forget the promise you made me?

Daniel startles. He thinks quickly. *

DANIEL
Actually, I was planning to invite you to the jewelry store tomorrow to pick something up. I was at your door when the power went out.

CLAIRE
(puzzled)
Pick something up? Is this part of uncovering the truth?

DANIEL
It's a symbol of trust between partners.

49 INT. BUDGET HOTEL ROOM - DAY 49

The room is small and furnished with cheap decor. Sarah, on the verge of a breakdown, sweeps everything off the table in frustration.

SARAH
This is what you call a sure-fire way to get our partnership back? We're stuck in a hotel, the company's stock is tanking, investors are fleeing—how are we supposed to bounce back from this?

KYLE
I'm about to secure a connection with the Griffith family. Once that happens, everything will change. *

SARAH
Daniel Griffith? The reclusive, mysterious, and ruthless head of the family? No one even knows what he looks like. How are you going to connect with him?

50 INT. BUDGET HOTEL ROOM - LATER - CONTINUOUS 50

KYLE
The Griffiths have been planning a grand banquet for the patriarch, Benjamin's birthday. I've already secured a way in.

SARAH
(surprised)
You got an invitation? How did you pull that off?

KYLE
That's right. The Griffith family extended the invitation to me. They finalized the guest list six months ago, but only announced it this week. Once I secure a deal with the Griffiths, who the fuck will Curtis be?

SARAH
And why are you so confident that Daniel Griffith will help you?

KYLE
Because of my talent! You'll see soon enough—sticking with me is the smartest choice you've ever made. And Claire? She'll be on her knees begging for mercy soon enough. *

**Episode 31**

51 EXT. GRIFFITH HIGH-END JEWELRY STORE - DAY 51

Claire and Daniel stand side by side outside the luxurious jewelry store. Claire glances up at the golden sign reading "Griffith."

CLAIRE
High-end jewelry, and under the Griffith family's brand. You're really part of the Griffith family?

Daniel's lips curl into a faint, teasing smile, a glint of mischief in his eyes.

DANIEL
And if I were? Would that make me special to you?

Claire freezes for a moment, but then laughs aloud. *

CLAIRE
The Costello family is already at the top. Whether it's a business or personal relationship, your family's background doesn't matter to me.

DANIEL
That's what I admire about you, Claire. Let's go.

52 INT. GRIFFITH HIGH-END JEWELRY STORE - DAY 52

Claire and Daniel enter the store together.

DANIEL
I'm here to pick up a ring I sent for maintenance...

Susan, a salesperson, glances at their modest attire with a look of disdain as she scans them from head to toe. Her expression shifts to surprise when she recognizes Claire.

SUSAN
Oh my, is that really Claire?

**Episode 32**

53 INT. GRIFFITH HIGH-END JEWELRY STORE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 53

CLAIRE
And you are?

SUSAN
I'm Susan, Kyle's aunt's daughter. You just got kicked out of the family by Kyle, so what are you doing in a high-end jewelry store? This place is for elite socialites. Shouldn't you be sleeping on a park bench somewhere, worrying about your next meal?

CLAIRE
(coldly)
It seems they didn't invite you to their wedding—or bother updating you on their current situation. Kyle's company stock has plummeted, investors have pulled out, and I've reclaimed ownership of the villa. So if anyone's sleeping on the streets, it's them, not me.

SUSAN
(through gritted teeth)
Impossible! Kyle is the youngest entrepreneur on the rich list, and incredibly successful to boot. His wife Sarah is a top-tier socialite and a role model for independent career women. How can it be like you said? You're just jealous, making up lies to tear them down!

CLAIRE
If you don't believe me, check their stock price.

SUSAN
What would a housewife like you know about stock prices? Besides, they're about to be honored guests at the Griffith family banquet. That proves they have the favor of the Griffith patriarch.
(MORE)

SUSAN (CONT'D)
Their future is limitless! Unlike you, a spiteful divorcée spreading rumors about your ex-husband.

CLAIRE
(calmly)
Clearly, they don't see you, their poor relative, as worth their time. Even if they do rise to fame and fortune, it has nothing to do with you. Yet here you are, bragging on their behalf. How pitiful. *

SUSAN
Don't think your sharp tongue can change anything! You're just a worthless woman nobody wants! *

DANIEL
(interrupting)
Who said no one wants her?

**Episode 33**

54 INT. GRIFFITH HIGH-END JEWELRY STORE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 54

Susan glances at Daniel. Her tone drips with sarcasm.

SUSAN
Already hooked up with a pretty boy? Figures. Maybe you cheated during your marriage, and that's why you got kicked out with nothing. Judging by his looks, I'd say he's a top-tier whore.
(to Daniel)
Kid, don't let her fool you with this act of elegance. Every penny she has comes from begging Kyle.
(to Claire)
Nothing here is something you could afford in this lifetime.

DANIEL
Oh? She doesn't need to spend a dime to buy these things.
(to Claire)
If you like it, we could buy the whole store.

SUSAN
(snide)
Big talk.
(MORE)

SUSAN (CONT'D)
What, you think this is some flea market where you shop for cheap trinkets? Stick to your bargain-bin accessories. Don't contaminate high-end jewelry with your presence.

DANIEL
(his tone cold, his expression darkens)
The only thing tarnishing high-end jewelry is a salesperson like you. I'm here to pick up the California Star ring. Right now. Immediately.

SUSAN
The California Star? That's the largest yellow diamond in the U.S. There's no way someone like you could own that! *

Susan gestures toward a sleek, secure safe.

SUSAN (CONT'D)
Even if I told you where it is, you wouldn't have the code to open it.

Daniel's gaze lands on the unfamiliar safe. He hesitates.

DANIEL
I forgot to ask Jack what password he set when it was stored.

**Episode 34**

55 INT. GRIFFITH HIGH-END JEWELRY STORE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 55

SUSAN
(mocking)
Hahaha! Stop trying to save face, I'm embarrassed for you. An inferior bitch like you should stick to what he's good at—why bother pretending to be high society?

Daniel steps forward, locating the fingerprint scanner on the safe. He presses his thumb against it. To Susan's shock, the safe unlocks with a soft click.

SUSAN (CONT'D)
(stunned)
You actually unlocked it?!
(MORE)

SUSAN (CONT'D)
Oh, I know, the ring must belong to one of your clients. You're just running errands for them, pretending it's yours so you can play the big shot. A divorced cast-off and a third-rate errand boy—you two are a perfect match.

DANIEL
(coldly, with a smirk)
You've ruined my mood. Don't bother coming back to work.

Susan freezes, then bursts into laughter, head thrown back.

SUSAN
You're really committed to this "boss act," huh? Let me tell you something: Because of my relationship with Kyle, the managers here have no right to fire me. Who do you think you are? *

Daniel calmly pulls out his phone and makes a call.

DANIEL
Jimmy, Griffith High-End Jewelry. I want you here in one minute.

**Episode 35**

56 INT. GRIFFITH HIGH-END JEWELRY STORE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 56

SUSAN
Oh, you even know our manager's name? He's incredibly busy—you think you can summon him like a servant? Only the head of the Griffith family could pull that off. * *

CLAIRE
Your professionalism is truly lacking.
(to Daniel)
Let's go. It's not worth wasting time on someone like this. I have Gary to remind the Griffith family to improve the quality of their store staff.

SUSAN
(mocking)
You? Remind the Griffith family? Hahaha! I see, the divorce hit you hard, and now you're deluding yourself with some heiress fantasy. Face it, you're out of tricks and looking for an excuse to make a run for it.

DANIEL
(calmly to Claire)
Just wait a little longer. Jimmy will be here any moment.

SUSAN
(sneering)
Oh, right, you said you'd have the manager here in one minute. Where is he? What happened to your big act?

The store's front door suddenly swings open. A middle-aged man in a perfectly tailored suit hurries in, looking tense. Spotting Daniel, his face instantly transforms into a deferential smile.

JIMMY
(respectfully)
Mr. Griffith! We had no prior notice of your visit—our apologies for the oversight. How can we assist you?

Susan's smile freezes.

SUSAN
Griffith… Mr. Griffith?

**Episode 36**

57 INT. GRIFFITH HIGH-END JEWELRY STORE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 57

DANIEL
(coldly, with disdain)
This salesperson insulted customers and fawned over the wealthy instead How does any of that align with the basic standards we set for our staff? *

JIMMY
Understood! I'll handle it immediately!

Jimmy shoots Susan a harsh glare, his tone stern and authoritative.

JIMMY (CONT'D)
You're fired! You're barred from working at any Griffith-owned business. Security, escort her out!

Susan collapses to the floor, completely devastated.

SUSAN
Impossible! There must be some mistake! Mr. Griffith would never associate with a woman like her! Manager, please, let me explain—

Two security guards step forward, dragging Susan out of the store. Claire watches the scene unfold. *

CLAIRE
So, you really are the head of the Griffith family.

DANIEL
Claire, I would never lie to you.

Daniel gestures subtly to Jimmy, who tactfully retreats.

CLAIRE
The real you isn't as strange as the rumors make you out to be. But I still don't understand—someone like you, how could you marry me this casually?

DANIEL
One day, you'll understand.

**Episode 37**

58 INT. GRIFFITH HIGH-END JEWELRY STORE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 58

Daniel retrieves a velvet jewelry box from the safe and takes out a ring. Its band is crafted in a delicate wreath-like design, holding a radiant 10-carat yellow diamond. *

DANIEL
Why don't you put it on?

CLAIRE
(hesitant)
For me?

Daniel gently slides the ring onto her ring finger. *

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
The fit is perfect—like it was tailor-made for someone. The design is unique. Does it have some special meaning?

Daniel's mind drifts back to a childhood memory.

FLASHBACK BEGINS:

59 EXT. SUNLIT GARDEN - DAY 59

A sunny afternoon. A young Claire, about five years old, holds a small ring woven from yellow flowers. She playfully * slips it onto the finger of a boy her age—young Daniel.

YOUNG CLAIRE
Now you're my husband!

YOUNG DANIEL
What's a husband?

YOUNG CLAIRE
It's the person I trust most, the one who'll stand by my side no matter what.

Young Daniel smiles warmly at her.

FLASHBACK ENDS

60 INT. GRIFFITH HIGH-END JEWELRY STORE - DAY 60

DANIEL
It's just a token—a symbol that you're the person I trust most, the one who'll stand by my side.

DANIEL (V.O.)
The day your heart truly belongs to me, I'll tell you the memories behind this ring.

Daniel looks down, his fingers brushing the ring lightly.

DANIEL
Come with me to the Griffith family banquet as the wife of the man in power, me. It's Grandpa's birthday, and I'll formally introduce you to everyone.

CLAIRE
All right, Mr. Griffith.
(playfully raises her hand with the ring and gives it a little wave)
I'll wear it to the banquet.

**Episode 38**

61 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT 61

The banquet hall is lavishly decorated. Guests, dressed in their finest attire, file in gracefully. *

Daniel and Claire have just entered when an ASSISTANT approaches Daniel hurriedly and whispers something.

ASSISTANT
Boss, something's up. You need to come with me.

Daniel glances at Claire.

CLAIRE
You should go. I'll be fine.

DANIEL
I'll be right back.

Daniel turns and exits through a side door. Meanwhile, Kyle and Sarah make their entrance into the banquet hall. *

SARAH
I'm wearing my most expensive dress and my finest jewelry for tonight's banquet.

KYLE
(confidently)
My dear, this banquet is hosted by the Griffith family. Once we make this connection, we'll be regulars in high society. Dresses, jewelry - you'll have as much as you want.

SARAH
It better be. I don't want another disaster like last time.

At this moment, Kyle and Sarah spot Claire across the room. She is gracefully taking a glass of champagne from a tray carried by a waiter. Both of them freeze, eyes wide in disbelief.

KYLE
(incredulous)
Claire?! Again? What's she doing here?

SARAH
That money-hungry cockroach? What else could she be here for besides trying to climb the social ladder? *

Sarah strides purposefully toward Claire.

SARAH (CONT'D)
(with a scornful smirk)
Well, well. I never imagined a woman like you - worthless, divorced, and utterly pathetic - would dare show up at an event like this.

**Episode 39**

62 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 62

CLAIRE
Who said I snuck in? I walked in here, no tricks, no lies.

SARAH
What a joke. Don't tell me you're claiming the Griffith family invited you? Everyone here is someone important, with extraordinary accomplishments. You? A nobody? Who would believe that?

CLAIRE
What surprises me is how Daniel let you two in.

KYLE
We have a great relationship with Daniel.
(with disdain)
(MORE)

KYLE (CONT'D)
But you? The Griffith family's banquet is one of the most exclusive events in the country. Even if they needed someone to sweep the floors or carry trays, they wouldn't pick a shameless, two-faced divorcee like you. *

GUEST D
Who is this woman? Did she really sneak in?

SARAH
If you really walked in fair and square, then show us your invitation. *

KYLE
Good thinking, Sarah. That way, she can't accuse us of falsely accusing her.
(to Claire)
Hurry up and show your invitation.

CLAIRE
Invitation? When Daniel brought me in, no one stopped us or asked for any invitation.

Sarah and Kyle exchange smug looks, while the crowd leans in. *

**Episode 40**

63 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 63

SARAH
(mocking)
You, a lowly country bumpkin, pretending to be close to Daniel? Hah! I bet you used some disgraceful tricks, crawling into who knows how many beds just to sneak your way in here.

KYLE
(arrogantly)
If you have any sense, leave now! We're discussing billion-dollar deals here. If your presence ruins the mood and delays the negotiations, you couldn't afford the consequences!

CLAIRE
(calmly)
If I leave, this banquet might not be able to continue.

KYLE
Claire, don't be ridiculous. Others might not know you, but I do. You're just an orphan with no parents, a shut-in housewife. How could you possibly have any connection to the illustrious Griffith family? Save yourself the embarrassment and leave before security has to step in.

SARAH
The Griffith family's leader is a mysterious man who never shows his face. Plenty of people try to use his name to con their way into places, but everyone knows he's a man. You? A low-class woman, making up such a pathetic lie just to stay here? Your shamelessness is truly astounding!

CLAIRE
Of course, I'm not the head of the Griffith family.
(with composure)
I'm his wife.

SARAH
(doubtful)
You? The wife of the Griffith family's leader?

**Episode 41**

64 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 64

SARAH *
Hahahaha, what a joke! Do you really think a noble family like the Griffiths is within your reach?

KYLE
(arrogantly)
Claire, I get it. You're bitter and trying to upset me with this ridiculous story.
(MORE)

KYLE (CONT'D)
But before you make up such lies, at least look in a mirror first. You're a penniless, jobless housewife with no status or career. Even I didn't want you. How could someone like you possibly catch the eye of the Griffith family's head?

SARAH
Marrying into a powerful, noble family? Dream the fuck on! You're not even qualified to be their cheapest servant! *

CLAIRE
Whether it's true or not, you'll know when Daniel gets here.

SARAH
(mocking)
You're telling me the cold, unreachable head of the Griffith family would step in to back up a divorced housewife? Claire, you're out of your mind!

KYLE
This crazy woman won't give up until she hits a dead end. She's shameless enough to keep clinging on.

SARAH
Exactly. Letting her stay here insults every respectable guest at this event. Security! Get this woman out of here!

DANIEL (O.S.)
So you're planning to throw out the lady of the Griffith family?

Daniel steps into the hall, expression cold and commanding. Sarah and Kyle freeze, their faces draining of color. *

**Episode 42**

65 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 65

Daniel, dressed impeccably in a black tailcoat, strides confidently to Claire's side.

DANIEL
(to Claire)
Sorry, I’m late.

Sarah glances at Daniel with disdain, her expression full of scorn.

SARAH
Hah, I thought you might be someone important. Turns out, it’s just you again - the boytoy! What’s the deal? You two con artists think vouching for each other will make your lies believable?

DANIEL
Ladies and gentlemen, I am Daniel Griffith, the head of the Griffith family. Claire is my wife, the lady of the Griffith family.

GUEST A
No one’s ever seen the Griffith family’s leader before. If he says it so confidently, could it really be him?

GUEST B
Hard to say. If the head of the family really married a divorced housewife, wouldn’t the Griffith elders object?

KYLE
(angrily)
Enough already! Do you think you’re impersonating some ordinary socialites? The Griffith family is a legend in the US! Low-class fools like you have no right to tarnish their name!

SARAH
If you can’t prove your identity, I’ll call security to throw these impostors out. Anyone object to that? *

DANIEL
Let’s see who dares.

Daniel raises Claire’s hand.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
The "Star of California" on her finger is proof enough. It is the ultimate symbol bestowed upon the Griffith family matriarch.

**Episode 43**

66 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 66

The surrounding guests notice the ring on Claire's finger.

GUEST A
(surprised)
Oh my god, look! That really does look like the "Star of California"!

GUEST B
I remember seeing it at an auction. The Griffith family head bought it for $50 million and declared it was meant for his future wife as a token of love!

Claire glances at Daniel, her expression calm but curious.

CLAIRE
So this is the symbol of the lady of the house?

GUEST B
Then… could Claire really be Mr. Griffith's wife and the future lady of the Griffith family?

SARAH
I thought you had real evidence. That ring? It's famous, but there are countless knockoffs. Claire, you've outdone yourself lying just to steal the spotlight from me. How pathetic.

KYLE
The "Star of California" is one of the most exquisite yellow diamonds in the world. Ordinary people might never even see one in their lifetime. Do you honestly think a penniless, divorced housewife like you could ever wear something like that?

SARAH
She's probably wearing some cheap street-market fake. That's all she could afford anyway.

CLAIRE
You're so sure it's fake. Could it be that you've seen the real one?

SARAH
Of course I have. I was at the auction. Oh, and Kyle bought me this "Azure Dream" right there.

Sarah dramatically extends her hand, showing off her ring. *

**Episode 44**

67 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 67

GUEST B
That's the "Azure Dream"! It was also one of the auction pieces. While it's not nearly as valuable as the Star of California, it still drew a lot of attention. Who should we believe?

GUEST C
Isn't it obvious? Kyle's a regular on the Young Rich List, and Sarah is a prominent independent woman with multiple accolades. They're far more credible than those two nobodies.

KYLE
This ring is Sarah's engagement ring. I bought it for $1 million dollars.

DANIEL
$1 million dollars?

KYLE
(smugly)
What's wrong? Shocked by the price? A bankrupt little idiot like you can't even imagine the kind of life where a single ring costs a million.

SARAH
I have at least a hundred jewelry sets in my collection. And then there's her - too poor to even splurge on a decent fake. Her vanity's so fucking huge, she resorts to flaunting cheap knockoffs. Pathetic. *

KYLE
Sarah's taste has been cultivated since childhood. While Claire struts around with some gaudy knockoff and dares to call that glass "the Star of California." Watching someone like you, who's never seen real luxury, pretend to be one of us is laughable. *

DANIEL
(with a cold smirk)
Calling yourself high society because you wear jewelry that's worth a million dollars? Now that's what's fucking laughable.

KYLE
What did you just say?

**Episode 45**

68 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 68

KYLE
(furious)
We may not be nobility, but do you think a lowly boytoy like you is? You'd be terrified if you knew who's backing Sarah!

SARAH
My uncle is the deputy general manager of the Costello Group's Florida hotel branch. Crushing you two would be as easy as squashing an ant!

CLAIRE
Well. I didn't know being a deputy general manager of a branch was something worth bragging about.

SARAH
You—! You ignorant housewife!

KYLE
That fake ring clearly doesn't count as proof of identity. Quit clinging on and leave already. Security!

Four SECURITY GUARDS enter the hall.

KYLE (CONT'D)
Throw these two fakes out! Don't let them ruin Mr. Griffith's banquet!

SECURITY GUARD A
(to Claire and Daniel)
The two of you? We'll give you a chance to leave on your own.

The four guards quickly surround Claire and Daniel.

CLAIRE
(to Daniel)
They don't seem to recognize you.

DANIEL
I haven't been managing the family's affairs for long. It's normal they don't know me yet.

Daniel's assistant, Jack, enters, holding a certificate. *

JACK
Stop! I have the auction certificate for the "Star of California"! Here, boss—

DANIEL
Take a good look. Then apologize to my wife, Claire.

One guest notices a reflective watermark and is shocked.

GUEST E
That's the official watermark from the auction house. It can't be faked! The "Star of California" is definitely his!

GUEST A
There's only one "Star of California." That means this Daniel really is the head of the Griffith family!

Kyle and Sarah stand frozen, their faces pale.

KYLE
(stunned, breaking down)
What? If he's truly the head of the Griffith family, then I… I called him a freeloader to his face… It's over. Everything's over!

SARAH
(panicking)
No… It can't be. He can't really be that Griffith family head, can he?

Just then, a voice cuts through the tension. *

MADELYN (O.S.)
Of course he is! And he's also my fiancé!

**Episode 46**

69 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 69

The door opens, and five burly bodyguards (1 head + 4 guards) * move to either side, and Madelyn appears in the middle, * walking towards Daniel with a menacing look and sharp eyes.

GUEST B
(in hushed awe)
It's the Sterling heiress! The Sterling family ranks third among the Four Great Families. Even she's here tonight?!

GUEST C
I heard she's been chasing after the Griffith family leader for years. Everyone knows about it. Looks like things are about to get interesting!

MADELYN
Daniel, you're the esteemed head of the Griffith family, yet you've lowered yourself to marry a discarded woman? Why?

DANIEL
(with displeasure)
Miss Sterling, watch your words when you speak about my wife.

MADELYN
Daniel, I am your rightful fiancée! Don't you see? Who else but me is worthy of you?
(to Claire, venomously)
And you, bitch, whatever your goal is, you better leave Daniel now, or I'll break your legs!

**Episode 47**

70 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 70

GUEST A
Madelyn Sterling grew up in a mafia family. She's notorious for her temper and ruthlessness. Claire's fucked now.

GUEST B
Madelyn and Daniel are a perfect match. If I were Daniel, I'd definitely choose Madelyn.

SARAH
(gloating)
Hah! Claire thought she had secured her place in the Griffith family, but look how quickly the real lady of the house showed up to take her down.

KYLE
Just wait. That bitch Claire is about to face her downfall.

Claire remains calm, her expression indifferent as she glances at Madelyn with thinly veiled disdain.

CLAIRE
Break my legs? You're the first person who's tried to threaten me with that.

MADELYN
You think I'm just bluffing? Let me give you some advice: know your place.
(MORE)

MADELYN (CONT'D)
I've known Daniel since childhood. Even if I broke your legs, he wouldn't turn against me for someone like you.

DANIEL
(firmly)
Madelyn Sterling, Claire is my one and only wife. As for you, you're just another guest tonight. If you don't rein yourself in, you'll pay the price for your disrespect.

MADELYN
You're actually defending her? She's nothing but a discarded, low-class woman with no status! *

DANIEL
I love her. And that makes her the best there is.

MADELYN
Love her? Impossible! You used to have feelings for me!

Claire raises her eyebrows slightly. *

**Episode 48**

71 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 71 *

GUEST A
Miss Sterling and Daniel are in love? Doesn't that make Claire the third party?

GUEST B
That Claire definitely doesn't deserve to marry into the Griffith family. She must have used some kind of trick to climb her way up.

MADELYN
I get it now. You were just trying to fend off your family's pressure to get married, so you grabbed some random woman as a shield, right? It's fine, I don't mind. Just leave her now, and I'll marry you!

CLAIRE (V.O.)
So Daniel rushed into marrying me just to find a strong shield, huh?

DANIEL
(annoyed)
Madelyn Sterling, that's enough. From start to finish, Claire has been my only choice.

MADELYN
Daniel, you're such a disappointment. You're rejecting me for these... secondhand goods!?

CLAIRE
(quietly, to Daniel)
It's fine if you're using me as a shield. After all, our marriage is just a business deal. I have my own reasons, too.

DANIEL
Claire, it's not like that...

Daniel wants to explain but is interrupted by Madelyn.

MADELYN *
Daniel, a scheming woman like her is only using you as a stepping stone to climb the social ladder! She's just a low-born nobody, a little slut who fawns over men!

DANIEL
Low-born? Claire is more noble than any of us will ever be.

**Episode 49**

72 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 72 *

MADELYN
You've been deceived by this bitch! I checked out her background. She only has a middle school education, no employment history, and a failed marriage behind her. *
(outraged)
And the title of your wife, your family's future matriarch, was supposed to be mine! She stole it from me!

CLAIRE
Miss Sterling, if I heard correctly, Daniel just denied having any feelings for you.

MADELYN
You—discarded piece of shit wife, you're challenging me? Trying to steal my man? Know your place!

CLAIRE
If Daniel never liked you, there's no such thing as anyone stealing anything from you.

MADELYN
You shameless slut! Who knows what kind of dirty tricks you used to seduce Daniel! Take a good look in the mirror—do you really think you're worthy of standing beside someone like him?

DANIEL
(furious)
My wife is none of your concern, and you have no right to judge her.

MADELYN
Daniel! Women like her, greedy and shameless, are a dime a dozen! They latch onto powerful families like ours for money and status! Let me show you who she really is!

Madelyn pulls out a blank check and throws it in front of Claire.

**Episode 50**

73 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 73 *

MADELYN
(arrogantly)
Here's the deal. As long as you leave Daniel, you can fill in any amount you want on this check. I'll make sure you live a life beyond your wildest dreams. *

CLAIRE
Money? I've never lacked it. Especially not pocket change like this. You'd better keep it for yourself, Miss Sterling, and invest in some etiquette classes.

MADELYN
(outraged)
You! Who do you think you are, pretending to be so noble in front of me?!

BENJAMIN (O.S.)
What's all this commotion about?

An elegantly dressed, silver-haired elderly man enters. *

MADELYN
(sweetly)
Oh, Mr. Griffith, you're finally here!

DANIEL
Grandfather, weren't you feeling unwell? Why did you come?

BENJAMIN
It's my birthday celebration; it wouldn't be right for me to miss it. What's going on? *

MADELYN
Mr. Griffith, it's all because of this shameless bitch! She's nothing but a prostitute who refuses to let go of Daniel and even dares to act all high and mighty in front of us.

DANIEL
Grandfather, don't listen to Madelyn. Claire is my lawful wife. In fact, her true identity is—

MADELYN
(cutting him off)
Enough! Daniel, why must you insist on being so blind?!

BENJAMIN
Alright, alright. It's my birthday today. Let's not argue anymore. For my sake, let's keep the peace.
(MORE)

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
However, as for this woman, Daniel, you'd better handle this yourself. Think carefully—you must not bring shame to our family.

SARAH
That's right. Today is Mr. Griffith's 80th birthday. Let's keep the mood joyful! Oh, and according to tradition, the younger generation should show their respect by presenting a special gift.

MADELYN
Exactly. I've prepared a "triple deluxe gift" in advance, just waiting for Mr. Griffith to arrive so I could present it to him.

BENJAMIN
Miss Sterling, you've gone to great lengths.

SARAH
Claire, weren't you so full of yourself just now? Coming to someone else's birthday party—surely you didn't come empty-handed?

MADELYN *
Of course, this low-born bitch must have brought nothing. Someone like her has never seen an occasion like this in her life. She wouldn't understand the basic etiquette of families like ours. *

DANIEL
Who says she didn't prepare anything?

**Episode 51**

74 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 74 *

DANIEL
My wife and I are one. Naturally, the gift for my grandfather is from both of us. No need for anyone else to worry about it.

SARAH
I knew it. Some people are just used to hiding behind their husbands. Look, even this so-called gift had to be prepared by Mr. Griffith himself.

CLAIRE
(calmly)
I'm happy that my husband would prepare something on my behalf. But as for the gift, I've prepared one myself.

SARAH
(mocking)
How surprising. You actually brought something. But considering your financial situation, what could it possibly be? Some bargain-bin item from a department store?

CLAIRE
A gift is an expression of goodwill. But if we're discussing value, I can assure you that my gift is worth ten times the combined value of all the other gifts here tonight.

BENJAMIN
Claire, a value ten times the total of all tonight's gifts is no small claim. I understand you may not grasp the scale of this event, so I'll give you a chance to take back that statement.

MADELYN
(her tone sharp) *
Hah! Tonight's guests are the elite of California's high society. For a penniless housewife like you to boast like this—it's absolutely laughable.

SARAH *
Miss Sterling, you might not know, but this woman has been boasting for ages. No one's managed to put her in her place.

MADELYN
(arrogantly)
Then tonight, I'll teach her a lesson about the true etiquette and grandeur of high society. Time to put her in her place!

**Episode 52**

75 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 75 *

Madelyn, brimming with confidence, snaps her fingers. Her servant, SERVANT A, enters the stage with three elegant hostesses, each carrying an exquisitely wrapped gift.

SERVANT A
(loudly announcing)
Miss Sterling has prepared three grand gifts to celebrate Mr. Griffith's birthday! The first gift—a masterpiece by the renowned artist Pollock, valued at 30 million.

As Servant A speaks, one of the hostesses unveils the first gift from beneath a velvet cover. *

GUEST B
A rare original by Pollock. Its value as a collectible is immense—you couldn't get something like this even if you had the money!

GUEST A
And that's just the first gift. *

MADELYN
Mr. Griffith, I know you have a fondness for fine art, so I made sure to acquire this just for you.

BENJAMIN
(pleased)
Thank you, Miss Sterling.

MADELYN
And knowing how much you adore Mrs. Griffith, the next gift is prepared especially for her, to lift her spirits while she's recovering away from home.

A black velvet tray is revealed, holding a necklace, two bracelets, and a pair of earrings. The set, crafted from pure gold and premium emeralds, dazzle in the light. *

SERVANT A
The second gift—an antique emerald jewelry set, valued at 60 million.

BENJAMIN
My wife loves emeralds. She'll be overjoyed when she sees this.

GUEST C
Emerald mines are becoming increasingly scarce. With gems of this size and quality, the elegance is unmatched.

GUEST D
Exactly! Now I'm dying to know what the third gift will be!

Servant A unveils the final gift, pulling back the velvet cloth to reveal what appears to be a certificate resting atop the tray.

**Episode 53**

76 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 76 *

SERVANT A
The third gift—a manor on Bill Mountain!

GUEST A
I've heard that estate is in the heart of California. Prime location! Only three manors were ever developed there, making it incredibly rare.

GUEST B
And this particular one is the best of the three, complete with a natural hot spring! *

MADELYN
Happy birthday, Mr. Griffith!

BENJAMIN
Excellent! I'm very pleased with all three gifts. Miss Sterling, you've truly been thoughtful.

MADELYN
So? These three grand gifts—each of extraordinary value—clearly show my sincerity.
(to Claire)
And you, a destitute and discarded woman, could never afford these even if you saved every penny for a lifetime.

SARAH *
She couldn't even scrape together a * fraction of the cost. And it's not just about money. She wouldn't have * the connections or qualifications to buy them. Ten times the value? What a joke. Does she think gifting is like offering some cheap fruit basket, like her kind would do?

CLAIRE
(coolly)
Are these what you call grand gifts?

MADELYN
(raising her voice)
Claire, what do you mean by that?!

CLAIRE
(calmly)
I simply think such trifles are unworthy of someone of Mr. Griffith's stature.

**Episode 54** *

77 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 77 *

MADELYN
(furious)
You stupid bitch! This jewelry set is a timeless treasure, the painting is a global rarity, and the estate is a priceless resource! How dare you say they're insignificant?

CLAIRE
They're good enough to impress most people, but they're hardly groundbreaking. For me, they wouldn't even be worth presenting.

SARAH
You've talked big for long enough. Where's your so-called "grand gift," Claire? Empty promises won't convince anyone. *

CLAIRE
It's on the way. Just wait a little longer.

SARAH
If you can't deliver, just admit it. Don't drag things out to save face and waste everyone's time.

KYLE
Claire, making Mr. Griffith and all of us wait like this, your gift better be as extraordinary as you claim. If this is just a stunt, you'll regret it.

MADELYN
(sneering)
Hah, I bet she's panicking. Claire, if your gift isn't just worth the total of all ours combined, but exceeds my three gifts tenfold, I'll get on my knees right here. Don't blame me for being ruthless otherwise.

BENJAMIN
Claire, if what you've prepared doesn't match your bold words, you owe everyone here an apology.

The grand doors suddenly swing open. Butler GARY enters, * flanked by three uniformed attendants carrying a meticulously crafted box. Two security personnel follow closely behind in * an grand scene. *

GARY
The Costello family presents a gift for the gala!

MADELYN
(startled)
The Costello family?

**Episode 55**

78 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 78 *

GUEST A
(excited)
The Costello family! The leader of the legendary Four Great Families! Are they attending the gala today?

Kyle, trembling with excitement, turns to Sarah.

KYLE
I recognize him—that's Mr. Gary Miller, the butler to the head of the Costello Group!

BENJAMIN
Meeting Mr. Miller is akin to meeting the head of the Costello family. I must greet him personally!

Overcome with excitement, the elderly Benjamin strides forward to greet Gary. Meanwhile, Daniel leans toward Claire, speaking softly.

DANIEL
You actually prepared a gift?

Claire simply smiles without answering.

GARY
The first gift from the Costello family—

Attendant B carefully opens the first box.

Inside the box is a radiant, golden, ancient crown. *

GARY (CONT'D)
This crown is a 16th-century royal heirloom of European aristocracy, adorned with the largest known blood diamond in existence. It symbolizes supreme honor. *

MADELYN
Just the blood diamond alone surpasses the value of my first two gifts!

Sarah's expression is a mix of shock and envy. *

SARAH
It's casually priceless... The Costello family is still untouchably elite...

GUEST B
As expected of a legendary family! Their offerings are extraordinary!

GUEST A
If a gemstone necklace can still be bought with money, this crown is beyond money. It's a symbol of power itself!

BENJAMIN
Such a priceless gift! Mr. Miller, please convey my deepest thanks to your master.

GARY
The second gift from the Costello family—

**Episode 56**

79 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 79 *

Servant B unveils the second velvet-covered item, revealing a single business certificate.

GARY
A private spaceflight company!

BENJAMIN
(eyes lighting up) *
Excellent, excellent! Commercial rockets are booming right now. Daniel, the head of the Costello family wants to partner with you in this industry!

Daniel glances at Claire, and they exchange a knowing smile.

GUEST B
This company is an asset that'll only continue to appreciate in value! It seems that in addition to absolute financial strength, the Costello family also has unconventional tastes!

GUEST C
Isn't this far more exciting than clichéd gold and silver? *

MADELYN
(muttering to herself)
No wonder my father always said the Costello family was the one he respected the most...

GARY
The third gift from the Costello family—

Servant B unveils the final velvet cloth.

GARY (CONT'D)
A private property deed for an archipelago in the South Pacific!

BENJAMIN
(stunned)
This... this is the archipelago I mentioned in passing years ago during a chat with old Mr. Costello!

GUEST D
Private islands are already hard to acquire, but gifting an entire archipelago in the Pacific? *

GUEST E
This is outrageous! I can't even imagine how they pulled it off!

GARY
The Costello family humbly presents these three modest gifts to celebrate Master Griffith's 80th birthday and wish him health and longevity!

Madelyn's face darkens. She calculates in her mind.

MADELYN (V.O.)
I've heard the head of the Costello family is a woman about Daniel's age. Sending such extravagant gifts... Could she be interested in Daniel too?

80 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 80 *

Servant B lifts the second velvet cloth, revealing only a business license.

GARY
A private spaceflight company!

BENJAMIN
(eyes gleaming) *
Excellent, excellent! The commercial space industry is booming right now. Daniel, the family head clearly wants to bring you into their industrial strategy!

Daniel looks at Claire, and they share a knowing smile.

GUEST B
This company is an asset that's bound to increase in value! The Costello family doesn't just have extraordinary wealth, they truly has impeccable taste as well!

GUEST C
Indeed! This is far more exciting than the usual cliché gifts of gold and silver!

MADELYN
(muttering to herself)
No wonder Father always said the Costello family commanded his utmost respect...

GARY
The Costello family's third grand gift—

Servant B lifts the third velvet cloth.

GARY (CONT'D)
A private deed to an archipelago in the South Pacific!

BENJAMIN
(shocked)
This is... the very archipelago I mentioned in passing to Mr. Costello years ago!

The room falls silent, then erupts in a wave of amazed gasps.

GUEST D
Private islands are hard enough to acquire these days, but they're giving him an entire Pacific archipelago! My God!

GUEST E
This is absolutely incredible! I can't even imagine how they managed it!

GARY
The Costello family humbly presents these three modest gifts to celebrate Master. Griffith's 80th birthday. May you enjoy good health and longevity!

MADELYN (V.O.)
I've heard the Costello family head is a woman around Daniel's age. Sending such lavish gifts to Mr. Griffith... could she have her eyes on Daniel too?

**Episode 57**

81 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 81

GARY
(smiling)
Master Griffith, the family head says this is just a small token of her appreciation... as your future daughter-in-law.

Madelyn's face shows alarm and unease.

MADELYN (V.O.)
Good heavens, I've been competing for the same man with the Head of the Costello family...

BENJAMIN
My thanks to Miss Costello! I absolutely adore these gifts! I don't know how I could ever repay her kindness! She's welcome to visit the estate anytime—I'll make sure she receives the finest hospitality!

Gary gives Claire a deep, respectful nod.

GARY
I'll take my leave now, Mr. Griffith.

BENJAMIN
Leaving so soon? Let me walk you out.

They both turn and exit the banquet hall.

MADELYN
The Costello Family Head's gifts far exceed the value of everyone else's combined by tenfold! Claire, your grand gift hasn't arrived yet, and you've already lost.

CLAIRE
These gifts were prepared by me.

SARAH
(skeptically)
By you?

The crowd stares at Claire in astonishment. *

CLAIRE
Weren't you going to kneel? Now that the gifts have been given, it's time to fulfill your end of the bargain.

**Episode 58**

82 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 82

MADELYN
(sneering)
These gifts are from the Head of the Costello family—what do they have to do with you?!

CLAIRE
I am the Head of the Costello family. *

GUEST C
Could she really be the Costello family head?

GUEST D
It's not impossible—after all, no one's ever seen the family Head's true face.

MADELYN
Have you lost your mind? Everyone knows you're just a divorced spinster with no skills or status!

SARAH
(sarcastically)
Exactly. Claire, if you were the Head of the Costello family, with access to such rare treasures, why would you be a mere housewife in the Ramon family, fussing about groceries all day long? *

KYLE
The gifts must be a coincidence, and she's trying to get a cheap deal of it. Claiming credit for the Costello family Head's gesture—how audacious!

MADELYN
Hmph, she even dares to compete with the Costello family head for a man!

**Episode 59**

83 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 83 *

MADELYN
Claire, do you think just because Daniel likes you, you'll become the Griffiths' daughter-in-law while resting on your laurels? Can't you see the Head of the Costello family has her sights set on him?

CLAIRE
And what about it?

MADELYN
Even I have to show respect to that family head. A commoner like you daring to compete with her for Daniel—you must be tired of living in California.

Claire's calm demeanor is tinged with subtle contempt. *

CLAIRE
At least you know your place. With your abilities, you indeed can't compete with me. *

MADELYN
Claire, you worthless pariah, you've looked down on me again and again, you keep clinging on to Daniel, and now you openly challenge the Head of the Costello family! I suggest you apologize to me immediately, or you won't leave this banquet hall today!

Claire speaks calmly. *

CLAIRE
You're the one who should apologize for your ignorance. You're not qualified to make threats in my presence.

**Episode 60**

84 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 84

MADELYN
Looks like you won't get it until I beat it into you! Let me show you how the Sterling family handles things!
(commanding her bodyguards) *
Teach her some manners! *

Four burly bodyguards in black suits approach Claire.

Daniel swiftly moves in front of Claire, his gaze sharp and threatening. *

DANIEL
Anyone who touches her becomes an enemy of the Griffith family. Don't say I didn't warn you.

Madelyn freezes, raising her hand to stop the bodyguards from advancing further.

MADELYN
Daniel, are you sure you want to turn against me for a woman like her?

DANIEL
(in a cold, deep voice)
I'll say this one last time: Claire is my one and only wife, the person I love most. I will not allow anyone to harm her.

**Episode 61**

85 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 85

Madelyn stands stunned. Sarah's eyes dart cunningly as she steps forward to fan the flames.

SARAH
Well, well, I underestimated you before, Claire. You're quite something— you've barely divorced your brilliant ex-husband and already climbed up the social ladder in such a short time, now you're arm in arm with the Head of the Griffith family.

KYLE
That's right. A woman I deemed beneath me somehow has the Griffith family head wrapped around her finger. The very same Head that even I look up to!

SARAH
She must have stalked him till he gave in, what else? That's what women like her do best.

DANIEL
Quite the contrary—I was the one who pursued Claire.

MADELYN
Pursued?! Impossible! Daniel, the unapproachable, cold, and mysterious Head of Family, pursuing a woman?

DANIEL
I've been drawn to Claire from the start. Her agreeing to be with me, it’s more than I could have hoped for.

CLAIRE (V.O.)
It’s true he was the one who proposed our contract marriage, but this is quite an exaggeration... He must be using me as a shield to reject unwanted suitors... or is he helping me annoy my ex-husband?

**Episode 62**

86 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 86

Madelyn watches the pair's shared gaze, burning with fury.

MADELYN
This is absurd! The man I've set my sights on, chasing after some common, worthless divorcee?

DANIEL
Claire is the greatest person I know, that’s why I chose her. But someone like you— so arrogant and opportunistic, with nothing to back it up? I could never be with you.

MADELYN
Don't forget, our engagement was agreed upon by both our families' elders! Rejecting me means opposing the entire Sterling family!

DANIEL
Are you sure the Sterling family stands with you? It was only a verbal agreement, and I personally called off the engagement with your father shortly after taking control.

MADELYN
Of course I don't believe it! Father has always given me whatever I wanted—he'll take my side on this for sure!

DANIEL
Then let's hear what your father has to say.

Daniel takes out his phone and dials Madelyn's father.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
Mr. Sterling, your daughter heard about the canceled engagement, and now she's causing a scene at the Griffith family banquet.

**Episode 63**

87 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 87

MADELYN'S FATHER (V.O.)
My deepest apologies for the trouble, Mr. Griffith. I'll remove her immediately.

MADELYN
Father! Even if Daniel won't be with me, he absolutely cannot be with this housewife! I hate that bitch! You gotta help me!

MADELYN'S FATHER (V.O.)
Enough! Haven't you embarrassed yourself enough? Come back at once!

MADELYN
(hysterical)
No, I'm not going back!

MADELYN'S FATHER (V.O.)
Return immediately, unless you want to be disowned by the Sterling family!

The call ends with a dial tone.

MADELYN
(to Claire)
Claire, cling to Daniel all you want—the Head of the Costello family will deal with you soon! Not even Daniel will be able to protect you then!

Madelyn storms out in a huff, bodyguards following close behind. *

SARAH
(frustrated)
I thought this Madelyn could drive Claire from her position. How disappointing.

KYLE
Well, since this is Claire's moment, we should take our leave.

As Kyle and Sarah prepare to slip away, Daniel notices their movement and calls out.

DANIEL
Mr. Ramon, Miss White. You disrespected the future matriarch of the Griffith family, and we haven't settled the score.

**Episode 64**

88 INT. GRIFFITH FAMILY BANQUET HALL - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 88

SARAH
Future matriarch? Claire hasn’t claimed that throne for sure yet.
(to Claire)
Claire, you must be so proud of yourself. You think you can get ahead by using a man? Don't be naive. We’ll see if the Head of the Costello family lets you off! Just wait—your good days are numbered!

They turn to leave. Daniel moves to stop them, but Claire holds his arm.

CLAIRE
(whispering)
Let it go. Now isn't the time to deal with them. Once we've uncovered the truth about the past, we'll settle things.

89 INT. GRIFFITH HOTEL PARKING LOT - NIGHT 89 *

Sarah and Kyle walk through the parking lot. *

SARAH
That bitch Claire, how could she become a wealthy man's wife! She's ruined all our plans again!

KYLE
If Daniel could fall for a woman like her, he can't be very smart! Just wait till I become an elite, he'll have to show me proper respect!

SARAH
But what do we do now? I can't swallow my pride seeing her so smug!

Sarah reaches her car. She spots at a distance (diagonally across from where Sarah is) - Madelyn leaning against a luxury car, her makeup streaked with tears. Sarah's lips curl into a slight smile. *

SARAH (CONT'D)
(approaching, feigning surprise, voice gentle)
Miss Sterling, what are you still doing here?

**Episode 65**

90 INT. GRIFFITH HOTEL PARKING LOT - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 90 *

MADELYN
(wiping tears with a cold sniff, indignant)
Do you have to ask? It's all that Claire's fault! Who does she think she is? In what way am I inferior to her?

SARAH
A woman like her— she has no family background, ability, or beauty—yet somehow she's gained the upper hand. I understand how you feel, Miss Sterling.

MADELYN
What's the use of talking about this! I want to know why she's won Daniel's favor.

SARAH
Because she knows how to play her cards.

Madelyn frowns, looking at Sarah with skeptical interest.

SARAH (CONT'D)
If you want to win over Daniel, you need to take initiative, create opportunities. Once you seal the deal, even the Head of the Costello family won't be able to interfere.

MADELYN
You'd better have a plan ready.

SARAH
You won't be disappointed. There's a cocktail party tomorrow night...

Sarah leans in close, whispering something in Madelyn's ear.

**Episode 66**

91 INT. HOTEL – COCKTAIL PARTY – NIGHT 91 *

The room is dimly lit. Daniel takes a glass from Attendant K and chats with guests, drinking without suspicion. The attendant turns away, and through his bluetooth earpiece comes Madelyn's voice.

MADELYN (V.O.)
Keep it discreet. Then bring him to my room. I'll handle the rest personally.

Claire stands nearby, concern flickering in her eyes as she sees Daniel press his hand to his forehead.

Attendant K promptly moves to support Daniel. *

ATTENDANT K
Sir, you're drunk. Let me help you back to your room to rest.

Daniel nods, gesturing for him to lead the way. The attendant supports him toward the corridor.

Claire sets down her glass, and quickly follows. *

92 INT. HOTEL – CORRIDOR OUTSIDE MADELYN'S ROOM – NIGHT 92 *

The corridor is quiet and dark. Attendant K leads Daniel into Madelyn's room. Claire watches from a distance, her gaze intent. She glances at the guest list on her phone, which clearly shows "906-Madelyn."

CLAIRE (V.O.)
Madelyn's room? Why are they taking Daniel in there?

Claire quickly types a text message: "906, Help." The recipient is "GARY."

The attendant locks the door and swiftly departs. Claire rushes to the door, tries the handle, but finds it locked. She takes out her phone and her room key card, using her phone's NFC to read the specific code from her card. She then easily uses the NFC app to create two new cards, writing the code onto them.

She touches both cards to the lock in succession. With the second card, there's a "beep" as the door unlocks.

Claire rushes into the room.

**Episode 67**

93 INT. HOTEL - MADELYN'S ROOM - NIGHT 93 *

Claire bursts in to find Daniel leaning against the bed, his face flushed, brow furrowed, forehead covered in cold sweat.

CLAIRE
Daniel!

Claire hurries to his side, supporting him.

DANIEL *
Claire? Why are you here...

CLAIRE
I saw something was off with you, so I followed. Your drink must have been spiked—I'm guessing it was Madelyn.

DANIEL
(with a cold laugh)
She actually... resorted to such a despicable tactic...

CLAIRE *
Don't try to talk. I'm getting you out of here.

Claire moves to help Daniel up, but hears footsteps and low voices outside.

ATTENDANT K (O.S.)
Miss Madelyn ordered that once she goes in, no one is to come near. Lock that door and don’t open it until morning.

Claire hears the door being locked again. She tries the handle, but it won't budge.

CLAIRE
The door must be secured from the outside... We can't open it from in here!

Outside, a chain secures the door handle, preventing it from turning.

**Episode 68**

94 INT. HOTEL - MADELYN'S ROOM - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 94 *

Claire scans the room for escape routes but finds no other exits. She takes out her phone to call Gary, but there's no signal.

CLAIRE
No signal—did they install a signal jammer?

She turns to Daniel and sees him struggling to maintain control.

CLAIRE (CONT’D)
(softly)
We might be trapped. Daniel, are you alright?

DANIEL
(breathing heavily, fighting to stay rational)
Don't worry... I can hold on... I won't lose control... but right now, you should keep your distance.

Claire watches Daniel with complex emotions as each deep breath reveals his painful struggle for control.

She steps forward, gently cups his face, lifting it. As Daniel tries to speak, Claire silences him with an unexpected kiss.

Daniel freezes, then closes his eyes, returning the kiss. His hands instinctively steady her shoulders, passionate yet restrained. Claire straddles his legs, the atmosphere between them suddenly intimate.

After a deep kiss, Daniel gently pushes Claire away, gazing at her intensely, his eyes burning yet controlled.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
Are you sure about this, Claire?

**Episode 69**

95 INT. HOTEL - MADELYN'S ROOM - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS 95 *

Claire answers Daniel with another kiss. Her lips trail downward, leaving marks on his shirt. She removes his shirt, her long hair brushing against his chest.

Daniel's breathing quickens, his throat tightening, ears flushed red. His trembling hands move to push Claire away, but at her touch, he cups her neck instead, pulling her into a deep kiss.

Claire had Daniel pinned, but in an instant, their positions reverse.

Clothes fall to the floor, his strong, veined hands cover her delicate ones, fingers intertwining...

CUT TO:

96 INT. HOTEL - MADELYN'S ROOM - NIGHT - LATER 96 *

The alarm shows 5:20 AM, still dark outside.

Daniel gazes lovingly at Claire's profile.

DANIEL
I love you, Claire.

Claire averts her gaze, trying to hide her emotional turmoil.

CLAIRE
Don't overthink it. Since we're married, even if just in name, it was my duty to help you.

DANIEL
(disappointed)
Is that all it was? But I'm serious. *
(MORE)

DANIEL (CONT'D)
That's why I'm confirming my feelings to you... no matter what, I don't want you to do anything you'll regret.

CLAIRE
You were drugged—that's why you're having these delusions. When you regain your senses, you'll realize these feelings aren't real.

DANIEL
(gentle but firm)
Claire, I'm more awake than you can imagine. I know exactly what I'm doing.

CLAIRE
Daniel, we don't need to complicate things between us.

Claire starts to rise, but Daniel gently catches her wrist. There's no force in his grip, just a subtle plea for her to stay. Claire seems moved, but then there's a knock at the door. She quickly stands, resuming her usual composed demeanor.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
Someone's here.

**Episode 70**

97 INT. HOTEL - CORRIDOR OUTSIDE MADELYN'S ROOM - NIGHT 97

The door opens revealing Claire and Daniel, both fully dressed. The butler Gary stands in the doorway, face etched with concern.

GARY
We've removed the chain from the door, and the lookouts have been dealt with. Miss, sir, are you both alright?

Claire notices several of Madelyn's bodyguards around the corner, bound together and gagged.

CLAIRE
I'm fine.
(to Daniel, coolly)
I'll be leaving now.

Claire turns and walks away, her steps quick and rushed. Gary swiftly follows. Daniel watches her departure from where he stands.

His phone rings and he answers.

ASSISTANT (V.O.)
Boss, we have a major crisis! Hackers have breached the company's systems—user data is at risk of being leaked!

DANIEL
What? Can we trace who's behind this?

Claire, now at a distance from Daniel, absently touches her lips with her fingers.

CLAIRE (V.O.)
I didn't reject him. I even took the initiative... And also...

CLAIRE
(to Gary)
What happened with Madelyn?

GARY
As per your message, I intercepted her on the only path to room 906.

CLAIRE
She should’ve recognized you as the Costello’s butler. I imagine she was terrified?

GARY
Just as you predicted, Miss. She confessed her plan and begged for mercy.

CLAIRE
Excellent.

Daniel catches up to them, his brow furrowed as he looks at Claire.

DANIEL
Wait, Claire! There's something only you can help with.

Claire turns with a puzzled expression.

98 INT. BUDGET HOTEL ROOM - DAY 98

Kyle sits dejectedly in a chair, tilting an empty bottle to his lips.

Sarah, immaculately made up, fastens her earrings in front of a mirror, shooting Kyle a look of disgust through the reflection.

SARAH
(contemptuous)
I must have been blind to think throwing in my lot with you would lead to a life of luxury. Look at yourself— you're utter trash.

KYLE
I was blind too! How could I have thought a woman like you would stand by me for better or worse!

Sarah pours herself a glass of wine, walks to Kyle, and looks down at him imperiously.

SARAH
I'm a gorgeous, talented woman. Why should someone like me go down with your sinking ship? I'll tell you a secret: I'm about to enter a truly elite family - the Griffiths.

KYLE
(furious)
You boot-licking bitch!

The TV news broadcasts a report about the cyberattack on * Daniel's company.

ANCHOR (V.O.)
Breaking news: A tech company under the Griffith family—one of the world's four most powerful families—has suffered a major cyber attack. A massive data breach threatens user privacy and could severely damage the company's reputation...

99 INT. BUDGET HOTEL ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 99

KYLE
Hahaha! Your social climbing scheme is ruined, you fool! Daniel Griffith's company is in chaos—they're finished!

SARAH
(with a smug smile)
Of course I know. This chaos is just step one of my plan.

KYLE
(incredulous)
It couldn't be... you launched the cyber attack?! You're insane, absolutely insane!

SARAH
Next, I'll sweep in as a white hat hacker to solve all their problems. Daniel will be forever grateful, and I'll naturally become part of his inner circle, his trusted confidante... *

KYLE
(shocked and angry)
Walls have ears, you know! You'll be caught and destroyed!

SARAH
(dismissive)
I do flawless work—who could possibly trace it to me? "Fortune favors the bold." If you had half my talent, your company wouldn't be in shambles.

Sarah's phone suddenly rings. *

**Episode 73**

100 INT. BUDGET HOTEL ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 100

SARAH
(sweetly, on phone)
Yes, you’re speaking to the second greatest hacker in the world, an expert in cybersecurity and AI. Help resolve your company's crisis? Of course, I'll be right there.

Sarah hangs up, adjusts her clothes, grabs her bag, and strides out the door with an air of superiority.

Kyle watches her leave, smashing his bottle in rage.

KYLE
Sarah White, if I'm plunging into the abyss, don’t think you can rise up instead!

101 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY 101 *

The conference room bustles with anxious employees—some on phones discussing the situation, others huddled in urgent discussion.

Daniel faces a group of five or six REPORTERS, his expression grave.

DANIEL
We're bringing in expert white hat hackers to patch the vulnerabilities in our system and ensure user data is secure.

REPORTER A
Is it true that some of the world's top hackers will be joining this operation?

Before Daniel can answer, Sarah enters with a sweet smile.

SARAH
That's correct. I'll be joining. I'm "Snow White," the world's second-ranked hacker.

Daniel's expression darkens at the sight of Sarah. The employees and reporters buzz with excitement.

EMPLOYEE A
That's "Snow White"! Finally we see her in the flesh!

EMPLOYEE B
I know her— the runner-up in the global CTF championships, the preeminent female hacker "Snow White"! No one can touch her except Scorpion, the world number one. Now that she’s on board, we’re saved!

102 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 102 *

SARAH
(brimming with confidence) *
I've handled many situations like this. There's no need to worry—this * is actually an opportunity to strengthen the company's cybersecurity system.

EMPLOYEE C
She's amazing—a true role model for women!

REPORTER B
What motivated you to help the Griffith Group through this crisis?

SARAH
Daniel and I have history. I couldn't stand idle while he faces a crisis. I'm happy to help him. *

EMPLOYEE A
A corporate leader and a top hacker, both brilliant and gorgeous—they're perfect together!

EMPLOYEE B
But isn't the boss already married?

DANIEL
Welcome, Miss White. However, the decision to work with you isn't mine to make. That falls to our new Technical Director, Claire.

From the end of the corridor, Claire approaches with commanding presence.

**Episode 75**

103 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 103 *

Sarah's expression falters at the sight.

SARAH
(with feigned regret)
Oh, what a shame.
(MORE)

SARAH (CONT'D)
I was looking forward to working with your company, but to think you'd entrust such a crucial technical director position to a mere housewife.

The employees whisper in surprise. *

EMPLOYEE C
So this Claire is the new director rumored to be parachuting in today? No wonder we'd never heard of her—she's just a housewife!

EMPLOYEE B
How can they put a housewife in charge of tech at such a critical time? She'll cost us all our jobs!

EMPLOYEE D
I've heard of her—she targets promising young men! Her ex-husband is Kyle, the Ramon company boss! Clearly, she's just riding the boss's coattails again.

Sarah grows more smug seeing everyone echo her sentiments.

SARAH
(shaking her head with a sigh)
Claire, running tech for a major corporation isn't like running a household. Without solid technical skills and experience, it's hard to command respect.

DANIEL
Claire is a professional hacker.

SARAH
Her? A hacker? Hahaha, don't joke around, Mr. Griffith. I understand you want to protect your wife, but she probably can't even name all the keys on a keyboard.

DANIEL
I have my reasons for my hiring choices.

SARAH
If you're so confident in your wife's abilities, why not have a little competition and let the results speak for themselves? That should satisfy everyone's doubts.

**Episode 76**

104 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 104 *

CLAIRE
Oh? What kind of challenge did you have in mind?

SARAH
Simple—a capture the flag competition. We'll see who can breach the web server and capture the core system's flag first. If you win, no one will question you again. But if you lose, you'll have to step down from your position. *

EMPLOYEE C
(whispering to nearby colleague)
Isn't Miss White being a bit arrogant, openly challenging the boss's wife like this?

EMPLOYEE B
Hmph, I say let someone with real skills replace a nepotism hire like Claire.

SARAH (V.O.)
I'm ranked second in CTF in the world— beating a housewife will be child's play.

CLAIRE *
Fine by me.

SARAH
For fairness' sake, if you win, what do you want?

CLAIRE
I don't need you to do anything. I just need you to answer a few questions.

Sarah eyes Claire warily.

SARAH (V.O.)
Questions? What could a fake hacker possibly have to ask me?

SARAH
Deal. What do you think, Mr. Griffith?

DANIEL
I support Claire's decision.

CLAIRE
Then let's begin.

**Episode 77**

105 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 105 *

Sarah and Claire sit across from each other, each with a desktop computer in front of them. The atmosphere in the conference room suddenly becomes tense. *

Sarah types rapidly on her keyboard with intense focus, occasionally glancing at Claire with a smug expression.

SARAH (V.O.)
Hmph, just wait until you lose, Chaire. Today I'll make you look like a fool in front of everyone.

Claire types methodically with quiet confidence. *

EMPLOYEE A
Who do you think will win?

EMPLOYEE D
Is that even a question? That housewife probably just knows her way around recipe websites. She can barely understand the interface, she’s typing so slowly. Claire’s clearly just putting on a show.

EMPLOYEE B
Snow White will definitely win. At the mere age of twenty she ranked second among all hackers in the world! Nobody except Scorpion could compete with her. But Scorpion's been off the grid for ages.

Sarah hammers at her keyboard with renewed determination.

SARAH (V.O.)
This Web challenge is harder to crack than I expected...

Sarah grows anxious, beads of sweat forming on her forehead as her typing slows. *

Meanwhile, Claire stops typing. *

Her screen displays: "Congratulations! You've captured the FLAG!"

CLAIRE
I've got the FLAG.

Sarah sits frozen in her chair, stunned.

SARAH
How... how could I lose...

**Episode 78**

106 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE – CONFERENCE ROOM – DAY – CONTINUOUS 106 * *

EMPLOYEE A
Wow, who is Claire really? She actually beat Snow White!

EMPLOYEE B
Yeah, she cracked that Web challenge so fast! Is that even humanly possible?

EMPLOYEE C
Looks like we underestimated her big time. "Housewife?" She's got real skills! *

SARAH
This contest was rigged! You and your husband must have conspired together. Claire already knew the vulnerabilities!

CLAIRE
You proposed this challenge. If you're accusing me of cheating, show your evidence. Otherwise, I could sue you for defamation.

SARAH
It's obvious! What evidence do I need? I couldn't possibly lose to a mere housewife!

CLAIRE
You still think that's all I am? Just a housewife?

SARAH
Even if you're a professional hacker, you couldn't beat me! I was second place in the international CTF competition! I'm a world-class hacker!

CLAIRE
Exactly. You said it yourself - second place. Isn't it natural for first place to beat second?

SARAH
What are you saying? That you're Scorpion, the first-place winner? Impossible! Absolutely impossible!

**Episode 79**

107 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 107 *

CLAIRE
That's right. I am Scorpion, the top-ranked in CTF. You've lost to me again, Snow White.

EMPLOYEE C
What? She's Scorpion? Did I hear that right?

Everyone shows expressions of shock and admiration. Daniel watches Claire with pride and affection.

CLAIRE
(seriously)
When you lose, you honor the bet. Now, as agreed, answer my two questions. First: The recent cyber attack on Daniel's company. Was it your doing?

SARAH *
Stop slandering me! If I did it, why would I offer to help solve it?

KYLE
Because you wanted to climb the social ladder and become the Griffith family matriarch!

Kyle approaches with disheveled hair and a hint of madness in his eyes, shouting at the crowd. *

**Episode 80**

108 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE – CONFERENCE ROOM – DAY – CONTINUOUS 108 *

KYLE
I'm Sarah's husband. I'm here to expose this woman's true colors – she's a ruthless viper who'll stop at nothing!

SARAH *
You worthless piece of trash. You see me doing well and come to kick me while I'm down? *

KYLE
I refused to be your accomplice! You told me yourself – you planned to wreak havoc with your hacking skills, then get close to Daniel by helping fix it! I recorded it all!

Sarah starts to speak, but Claire cuts her off.

CLAIRE
Besides witness testimony, Sarah, your attack methods and approach matched exactly how you competed just now. Unfortunately for you, I've already fixed the problems you created.
(to reporters)
Besides patching all vulnerabilities, I've implemented multiple layers of encryption and protection to ensure the company's data security.

EMPLOYEE A
As expected of Scorpion - her technical prowess is beyond our imagination!

EMPLOYEE B
Yeah, the boss's wife is our company's savior! With her in charge, we'll never have security issues again!

CLAIRE
Now for my second question. Everyone remembers the "accident" with the Costello's family's autonomous driving system, right?

Sarah's expression turns to panic.

**Episode 81**

109 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 109 *

CLAIRE
Right after the crash, when I checked the backend logs, I only found system records that were seemingly normal.

The electronic display shows images of the crashed vehicle and backend log data.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
But recently, Daniel helped me recover the vehicle's hidden black box. The car's offline storage retained partial logs from that day. When we read the chip data, we found an anomalous command whose timestamp didn't match the sequence of commands in the backend logs - those normal entries were fake. This confirmed someone engineered that crash.

The crowd gasps as reporters rush forward to take photos.

REPORTER A
What?! So that accident was deliberate! This is an earth-shattering revelation!

EMPLOYEE C
Who was it? Who would do something so heinous?

CLAIRE
It was you, wasn't it, Sarah?

SARAH
So what? That was the Costello family's problem. What's it got to do with me?

CLAIRE
Sarah, it’s all thanks to your recent hacking attempt. All attackers inevitably leave traces of their identity. Through these, I found crucial evidence pointing to you - IP addresses and a signature code pattern in the hidden logs, a distinctive tool commonly used by Snow White.

SARAH
That evidence can all be fabricated! You're just trying to ruin my reputation! Well, it won't work! Even being the wife of the Griffith heir doesn't give you the right to twist the truth!

DANIEL
We knew Ms. White wouldn't confess easily. That's why I brought in your "star witness."

Security guards escort Witness A in.

WITNESS A
Sarah made me do it back then. Just to gain some market share, she ordered me to tamper with the code and cause that crash. She promised me a fortune, and I was foolish enough to agree.

SARAH
Shut up! I don't even know you! *

WITNESS A
You'd do anything for your own benefit. I won't take the fall for you anymore!

**Episode 82**

110 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 110 *

Reporters frantically take photos. *

REPORTER A
This is breaking news! Sarah White, once hailed as a role model for women, turns out to be the mastermind behind the Costello family tragedy.

EMPLOYEE D
God, this woman is terrifying. Cultivating this image of a self-made success, while under the surface, she has zero morals when it comes to money.

SARAH
That's not true! Claire's making it all up because she's jealous! Jealous that Kyle loves me, jealous of my success! *

CLAIRE
The reason I investigated was because the people who died in that accident... were my father and brother. I am the current head of the Costello family - Claire Costello. *

EMPLOYEE B *
So Claire isn't just brilliant, she's from such an extraordinary background - the head of the Costello family!

EMPLOYEE A
Ah, the boss and his wife are truly a perfect match!

Kyle collapses to the floor, overwhelmed with regret.

KYLE
What? She's the head of the Costello family?! Dear God, what have I thrown away!

SARAH
The head of the Costello family?! Why - you born with everything, why did you still have to destroy everything I worked so hard to build! Let's go to hell together!

Sarah lunges at Claire like a woman possessed--

**Episode 83**

111 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 111 *

Daniel's assistant Jack and two security guards restrain Sarah, pinning her to the ground. *

CLAIRE
Sarah White, you tampered with code that led to my family's death, maliciously infiltrated the Griffith network systems - it's time you're judged and punished in court!

SARAH
So what! I'll never admit defeat! Just you wait!

The guards drag the hysterical Sarah away.

Kyle approaches Claire, looking at her with desperate appeal.

KYLE
Claire, I didn't know Sarah's true nature before. I was deceived by that poisonous woman into leaving you! Let's start over, please? Trust me, Daniel might have some money, but he'll never love you like I do!

CLAIRE *
A man who willingly has an affair, then blames everything on the woman once he's caught - how good could you be for me?

DANIEL
Infidelity, ingratitude, and now trying to convince my wife to divorce me right in front of me.
(MORE)

DANIEL (CONT'D)
Since you've such a complete lack of integrity, no Griffith brand will ever work with you again.

EMPLOYEE B
Kyle's finished. He's offended the heads of both the Griffith and Costello families. Forget California - no company in America will work with him now.

Kyle breaks down in tears, falling to his knees begging. He crawls toward Claire's dress.

KYLE
I was wrong, please forgive me! *

Kyle reaches for the hem of Claire's dress, but she steps away.

KYLE (CONT'D)
I was blind before, I didn't recognize your true worth! Give me one more chance! Please?

CLAIRE
Security, throw him out.

Two guards step forward and grab Kyle. His demeanor instantly changes.

KYLE
Claire! Don't think you're so special! I'm the youngest genius entrepreneur - one day you'll all bow before me!

The guards drag the defiant Kyle out.

Daniel takes Claire's hand, and they share a smile.

**Episode 84**

112 INT. GRIFFITH GROUP OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS 112 *

CLAIRE
Thank you, Daniel.

Daniel lifts Claire's hand, the Star of California ring sparkling brilliantly on her finger.

DANIEL
We put rings on each other's fingers because "we're the people who trust each other most, who can fight side by side."

CLAIRE
(confused)
But I never put a ring on your finger...

DANIEL
Don't you remember? When we were children, you put a woven flower ring on my finger and said, "Now you're my husband."

Daniel takes a small box from his pocket containing a preserved flower ring.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
I wanted to tell you - from that moment on, I've been waiting for you. I prepared the Star of California for you too. I always hoped I could put it on your finger one day.

CLAIRE *
Now I remember! I thought we just had a marriage of convenience. I didn't realize you'd "planned" this all along.

DANIEL
But I never knew how you felt... Will you still put this ring on my finger now?

Claire slips the preserved flower ring onto Daniel's finger.

Claire softly kisses Daniel, looking deep into his eyes.

CLAIRE
Sorry to keep you waiting, my husband. I love you, Daniel.

They share a passionate kiss as everyone around them cheers in celebration. *